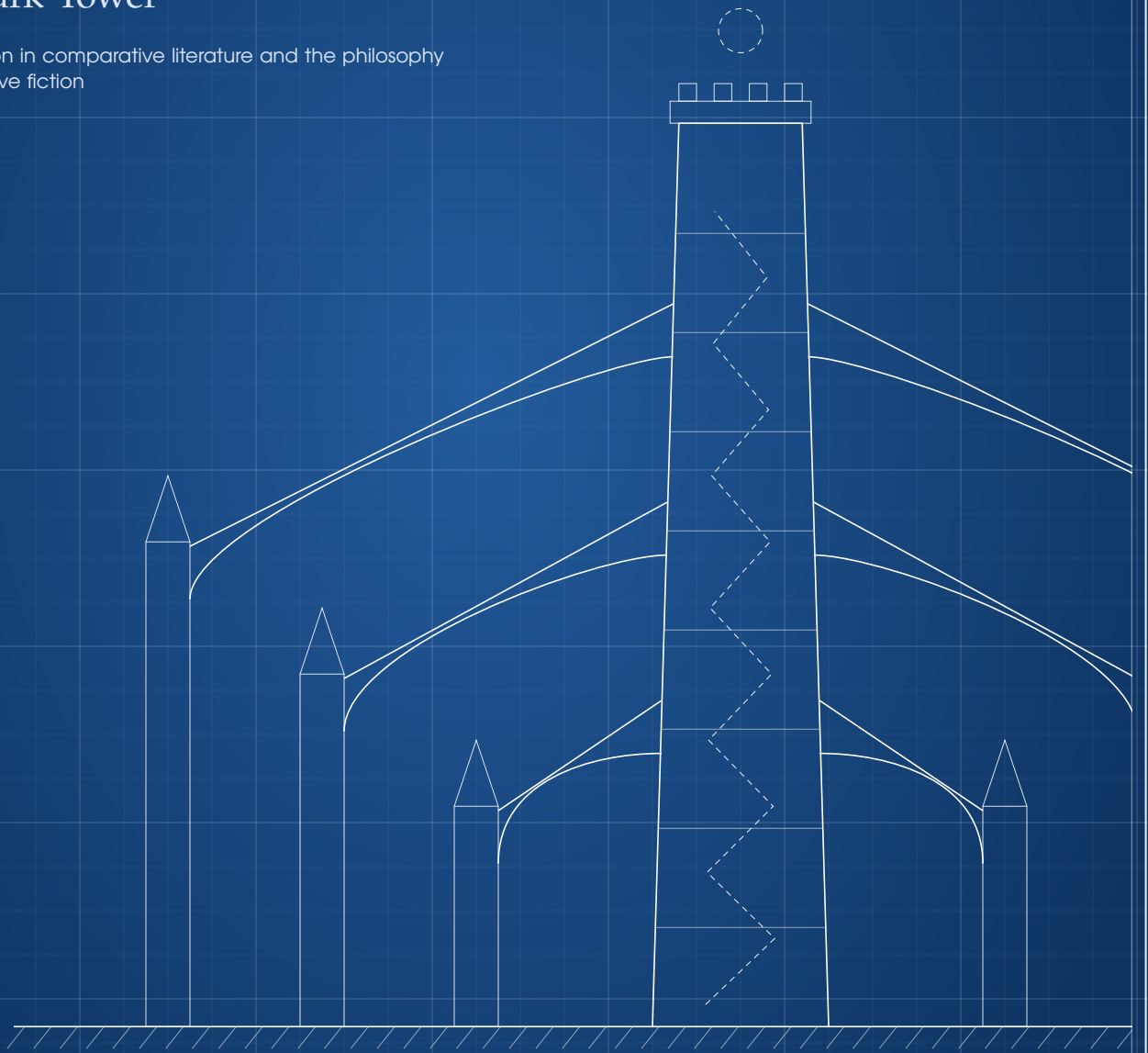
The Hub and the Host

Kenotic Axiality, Olifantine Repetition, and the Ethics of Convocation in Stephen King's The Dark Tower

A dissertation in comparative literature and the philosophy of speculative fiction

2026



The Hub and the Host

Elevation of the Tower

Abstract

This dissertation argues that Stephen King's *Dark Tower* cycle (seven volumes, 1982–2004, with an interpolated eighth, 2012) is the most sustained experiment in late-twentieth-century letters in what it names **kenotic axiality**: a cosmology, a political theology and a poetics organized around a center whose power to sustain depends upon its remaining unoccupied. Criticism has read the cycle's notorious ending—Roland Deschain's ascent of the Tower, which returns him to the desert of the first sentence—as punishment, as authorial evasion, as a gloss on Nietzschean recurrence, or as metafictional play. The present study reads it instead as the formal proof of the cycle's metaphysics.

Part One reconstructs the genealogy King assembled by bricolage: the Scottish tale of Childe Rowland and its Shakespearean fragment in *King Lear*; Browning's "Childe Roland to the Dark Tower Came" (1855) and Harold Bloom's theory of the internalized quest-romance; the olifant of the *Chanson de Roland*; Malory's Arthur and Mordred; the Grail romances of Chrétien and Wolfram; Eliot's *The Waste Land*; Tolkien, Leone, Ford and Kurosawa; Bunyan and Thomas Wolfe. Part Two reads the cycle's cosmology (the Prim, the Beams, the Guardians, the Rose, *ka*) against Laozi's empty hub, Boethius's providential center, Dante's *punto* and *candida rosa*, Lurianic *tzimtzum*, Eliade's *axis mundi* and Heidegger's critique of technological enframing; its political theology against Schmitt's *katechon*, Lefort's empty place of power, Benjamin, Agamben, Girard and Le Guin's Omelas; its psychology against Freud's repetition compulsion, Lacan's theory of the drive and Jung's alchemical individuation; and its metafiction against Genette, McHale, Unamuno, Borges and Hofstadter. Part Three situates the cycle among speculative and philosophical fictions—Tolkien, Moorcock, Zelazny, Eddison, Gene Wolfe, Miller, Hoban, Le Guin, Dick, Herbert, Stapledon, Clarke, McCarthy, Chiang—and proposes a typology of fictional centers: the throne, the balance, the machine, the list, the absent god, and the empty hub.

From these materials the dissertation derives five theses. (I) *Kenotic Axiality*: the Tower sustains the multiverse only while its summit remains unoccupied; its darkness is the visible form of a withdrawal. (II) *Buttressed Transcendence*: the vertical is an effect of the horizontal; the Beams bear the Tower as flying

buttresses bear a Gothic nave, so that the quest's cosmological achievements are lateral acts of convocation, accomplished before the summit is reached. (III) *Centripetal Usurpation*: evil in the cycle is the attempt to seize, fill or complete the center, and Roland's climb is formally identical with the Crimson King's project, as the double paternity of Mordred demonstrates. (IV) *The Horos Principle*: arrival at an unoccupiable center necessarily entails return; the loop is the Tower's mercy—a Valentinian Limit that restores the seeker to himself—and not a sentence passed upon him. (V) *Olifantine Repetition*: the loop is repetition with a difference, and the difference is the Horn of Eld, a hollow instrument that answers Browning's "slug-horn," a word descended, through Chatterton's misprision of *slogan*, from the Gaelic *sluagh-ghairm*, the cry of a host. A corollary, *the Transfer of the Horn*, locates the cycle's final agency in the rereader, who carries forward the memory Roland lacks. *The Dark Tower* is accordingly reclassified as a **katechontic romance**: a quest-narrative whose success consists in the restraint of its own completion, and whose ethics is not ascent but convocation.

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ξυνὸν γὰρ ἀρχὴ καὶ πέρας
ἐπὶ κύκλου περιφερείας.

For beginning and end are common
on the circumference of a circle.

Heraclitus, fr. 22 B103 DK

Thirty spokes share a single hub;
in the hub's nothing lies the use of the cart.

Laozi, *Daodejing* 11

Dauntless the slug-horn to my lips I set,
And blew. "Childe Roland to the Dark Tower came."

Robert Browning, "Childe Roland to the Dark Tower Came" (1855), st. XXXIV

Note on Texts, Editions and Abbreviations

King's cycle is cited parenthetically by the abbreviations tabulated below, followed where necessary by part and chapter, because pagination diverges widely across the Donald M. Grant limited editions, the trade and mass-market editions, and the revised *Gunslinger* of 2003. The revised *Gunslinger* is cited unless the 1982 text is specified (TG 1982); where the revision bears on the argument—above all in Chapter One—both texts are considered. King is quoted only in a handful of short formulae that have become proverbial among the cycle's readers ("the world has moved on"; "ka is a wheel"; "all things serve the Beam"); otherwise the argument proceeds by paraphrase and reference, as befits both the integrity of the primary text and the conventions governing quotation from copyrighted work. Public-domain texts are quoted directly. Translations from Greek, Latin, Old French, Middle High German, Italian and Classical Chinese are the author's unless otherwise indicated.

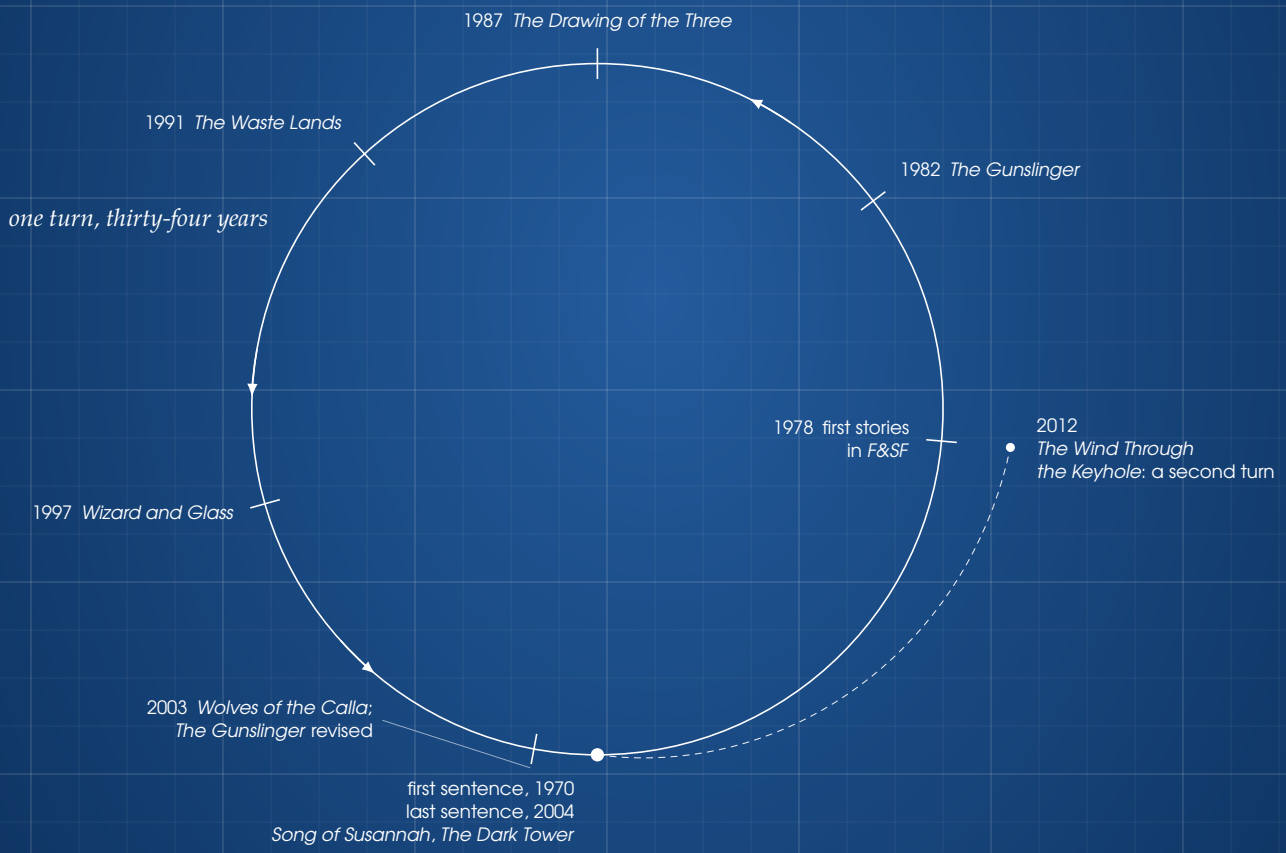
Ancient, medieval and early-modern texts are cited by their standard divisions: Heraclitus by Diels–Kranz number; Plato and Aristotle by Stephanus and Bekker pagination; Boethius by book and prose or metre; Irenaeus by book, chapter and section; Dante by cantica, canto and line; the *Chanson de Roland* by line of the Oxford manuscript; Shakespeare by act, scene and line; Browning by stanza; *The Waste Land* by line. Claims of source and influence are graded throughout by the three-tier scheme set out in the Introduction (§0.4): attested (A), transmitted (B) and resonant (C).

Abbr.	*Work*	*First published*
TG	*The Dark Tower I: The Gunslinger*	1982 (stories in *F&SF*, 1978–81); revised and expanded 2003
DoT	*The Dark Tower II: The Drawing of the Three*	1987
WL	*The Dark Tower III: The Waste Lands*	1991
WG	*The Dark Tower IV: Wizard and Glass*	1997
WTK	*The Wind Through the Keyhole* (set between WG and WC)	2012
WC	*The Dark Tower V: Wolves of the Calla*	2003
SoS	*The Dark Tower VI: Song of Susannah*	2004
DT	*The Dark Tower VII: The Dark Tower*	2004
SL	*'Salem's Lot*	1975

Abbr.	*Work*	*First published*
ST	*The Stand*	1978; complete and uncut 1990
It	*It*	1986
Ins	*Insomnia*	1994
HiA	*Hearts in Atlantis*	1999
OW	*On Writing: A Memoir of the Craft*	2000
BH	*Black House* (with Peter Straub)	2001

0 *Introduction*

The Scandal of the Summit



What kind of center is it that cannot be occupied, and what follows for those who approach it?

0.1 *The sentence that returns*

"The man in black fled across the desert, and the gunslinger followed." King has dated the composition of this sentence to 1970. It opens *The Gunslinger* and, restored verbatim, it closes *The Dark Tower* thirty-four years later—an interval that equals, by a coincidence the cycle's own numerological habits license us to notice, the number of stanzas in Browning's poem. Between its two appearances lie some four thousand pages, seven (later eight) volumes, a multiverse of interpenetrating worlds, the deaths of nearly every companion Roland Deschain acquires, and the entrance of the author himself into the fiction. At the end Roland crosses the field of roses that surrounds the Tower, climbs a stair whose rooms contain nothing but the relics of his own life, opens a door at the summit that bears his name, and finds himself once more in the desert, pursuing once more a quarry already dead, with no memory of the circuit he has completed save a faint ache of recognition.

The ending is famous, and it is prefaced by an embarrassment. Before the final ascent the narrator—a voice that by this point can no longer be distinguished from King's own—turns to the "Constant Reader," concedes that the true ending may disappoint, invites those content with the ending just given (Susannah Dean's passage through a door drawn by an artist into a snowbound Central Park, where versions of Eddie and Jake await her as brothers) to stop there, and then proceeds regardless (DT, Coda). The cycle thus ends twice: once horizontally, in a reunion; once vertically, in an ascent that becomes a return. The first ending belongs to the host, the second to the hub. This dissertation is an attempt to explain why the cycle requires both, and why the second is not—as it has so often seemed to readers—a cruelty.

0.2 *Four insufficient readings*

Four interpretations of the loop dominate criticism and readerly commentary alike, and each perceives something real. The *penal* reading treats the return as damnation: a Sisyphean sentence for the lives Roland spent to reach the Tower—the boy he let fall beneath the mountains, the girl burned at Mejis, the town he exterminated at Tull. The text gives this reading warrant, since the narrator intimates that the reappearance of the Horn of Eld among Roland's possessions marks a chance to do better. But punishment presupposes a judge, and the Tower, as Chapter Two will show, has no occupant; a sentence without a sentencer is not a sentence but a structure.

The *evasive* reading treats the loop as a refusal of closure born of authorial exhaustion, of the commercial prudence that keeps franchises open, or of the physical and psychic toll of King's 1999 accident. Yet the revised *Gunslinger* of 2003, prepared while the final volumes were being completed, retrofits the

beginning to the end with conspicuous care, and an ending prepared by the whole cycle's lexicon of wheels, circles and returns is not an evasion but a design. The *Nietzschean* reading treats the loop as an allegory of eternal recurrence, the "heaviest weight" of *The Gay Science* (§341) and the vision of the gateway in *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* III. But Nietzsche's return is the return of the same, whereas Roland's is not: he now carries the Horn. Zarathustra himself rebukes the dwarf who glibly announces that time is a circle; the formula is not the thought. The *metafictional* reading, finally, treats the ending as a postmodern game with frames—the author has entered his book, and the book declines to close. But metafiction in *The Dark Tower* is not ironic. It is soteriological: characters die to save their author, and the author is rendered as a servant rather than a sovereign.

Each reading, then, explains a feature; none explains the crux. The crux is that the telos of four thousand pages is structurally incapable of holding the hero who reaches it. The cycle does not answer the question its readers bring to it—*what is at the top of the Tower?*—but a stranger one: *what kind of center is it that cannot be occupied, and what follows for those who approach it?* The whole of this study is an answer to that question.

0.3 *The state of the question*

Scholarship on the cycle has been largely archival, lexical and source-critical, and its achievements are considerable. Douglas E. Winter's *Stephen King: The Art of Darkness* (1984) placed *The Gunslinger* at the idiosyncratic margin of King's early career, a genre anomaly written in a register unlike his horror. Bev Vincent's *The Road to the Dark Tower* (2004) and *The Dark Tower Companion* (2013) reconstructed the cycle's composition and publication history with documentary precision. Robin Furth's *Concordance* (2003–2005; consolidated 2012), begun as a working reference for King himself, catalogued the cycle's lexicon, geography, genealogy and chronology; it is indispensable precisely because it declines to interpret. Heidi Strengell's *Dissecting Stephen King* (2005) situated King within the Gothic and within literary naturalism, whose determinisms bear directly on the problem of *ka*. Patrick McAleer's *Inside the Dark Tower Series* (2009) mapped the cycle's art, evil and intertextuality, and Tony Magistrale's studies, from *The Moral Voyages of Stephen King* (1989) to *Stephen King: America's Storyteller* (2010), established the ethical seriousness of King's project and his place in American letters. These studies establish what the cycle contains and whence it came. None proposes a unified account of what its sources are doing *together*. The inventory of intertexts has outrun interpretation; the present study seeks to restore the balance by asking upon what single structural problem the sources converge.

The reception history supplies an irony worth pausing over. The critic best equipped to theorize the cycle was Harold Bloom, whose essay "The Internalization of Quest-Romance" (1969) and whose chapter on Browning in *Poetry and Repression* (1976), "Browning: Good Moments and Ruined Quests," furnish the nearest theoretical model of King's structure: a quest turned inward, in which the adversary is the quester's own belatedness and failure is converted into a peculiar triumph. Bloom edited the volume on King in the Modern Critical Views series (1998); but when the National Book Foundation awarded King its Medal for Distinguished Contribution to American Letters in 2003, Bloom denounced the award in the *Boston Globe* (24 September 2003) as a symptom of the degradation of American reading. The theorist of the ruined quest thus declined to recognize the most extensive ruined quest of his generation. The episode is a small allegory of the problem this study addresses: the cycle's categories are high-literary, its materials popular, and critics have too often assumed that the latter disqualify the former. Bloom's categories, turned upon King, prove more hospitable than Bloom's judgment.

0.4 *Method: genealogy, comparison, resonance*

The dissertation proceeds by three operations. *Genealogy* reconstructs the sources King names, quotes or evidently rewrites. *Philosophical exposition* returns the ideas those sources carry to their originators—from Heraclitus and Laozi to Kierkegaard, Freud and Schmitt—in order to recover what the ideas meant before they were embedded in fiction. *Comparison* sets the cycle among speculative and philosophical fictions that confront the same structural problem by other means. To prevent these operations from collapsing into one another, every claim of connection is graded. *Grade A* (attested) designates sources King names, quotes or borrows titles from: Browning, Tolkien, Leone, Eliot, Adams, Baum as mediated by MGM, Thomas Wolfe, and King's own prior fiction. *Grade B* (transmitted) designates traditions that demonstrably reach King through cultural mediation rather than study: Arthurian and Grail romance, the Western, Christian eschatology, the tarot, and the popular currency of Jung and Nietzsche. *Grade C* (resonant) designates structural homologies with traditions King need never have read—Laozi and Zhuangzi, Boethius, Luria, Valentinian Gnosticism, Schmitt, Lefort—adduced not as influences but, in Wai Chee Dimock's sense (1997), as frequencies at which the text becomes newly audible across time.

The cycle supplies its own warning against the abuse of the third grade. Jake Chambers's Final Essay, "My Understanding of Truth," a surrealist collage of images from a world he has not yet entered, receives an A+ from a teacher who praises its symbolic density (WL); the satire of overreading is exact, yet every image in the essay proves literally true in Mid-World. The passage dramatizes

within the fiction the problem Umberto Eco formalized as the distinction between interpretation and overinterpretation, in which the *intentio operis*—the coherence of the work itself—sets the limit to the reader's invention (Eco 1990; 1992). The present study accordingly admits a Grade C resonance only when it resolves a crux internal to the cycle that the attested sources leave unresolved: the double paternity of Mordred, the emptiness of the Tower's rooms, the erasure of the Crimson King, the return of the Horn, and the doubling of the ending. A resonance that explains nothing is decoration; a resonance that explains a crux is evidence.

0.5 *The argument in outline*

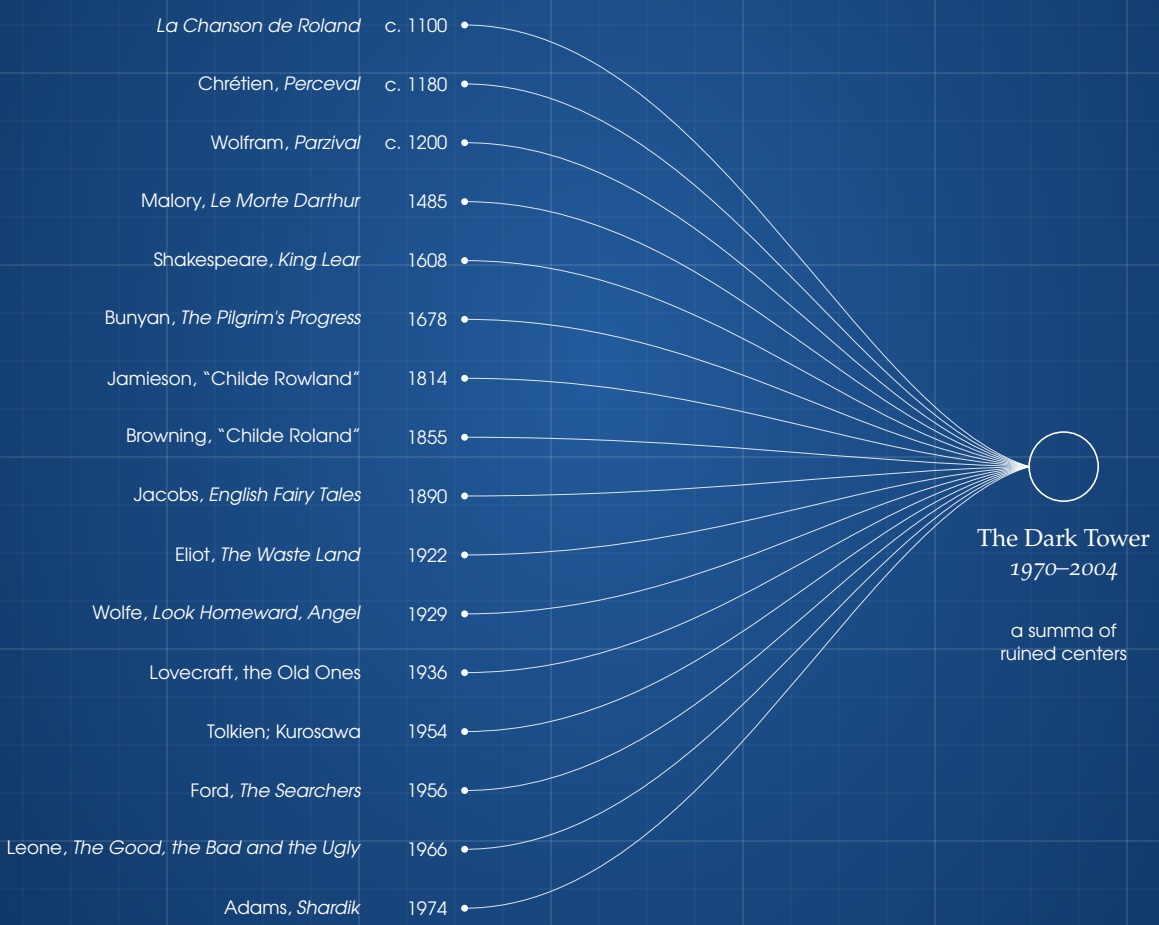
Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of the quest from the Scottish tale of Childe Rowland to Eliot and Leone, and discovers that every source King chose narrates a center that cannot be passed through: a hill opened only by circling it against the sun, a turret "blind as the fool's heart," a horn blown too late, a question unasked, a door that closes upon the hero. Chapter Two reads the cycle's cosmology as a theory of the empty hub, in dialogue with Laozi, Boethius, Dante, Luria and Heidegger. Chapter Three reads Gilead, the gunslingers and the Crimson King through political theology, above all the Pauline and Schmittian figure of the *katechon*, the power that restrains the end. Chapter Four considers sacrifice—Jake's fall, the harvested children of the Calla, the burning of Susan Delgado—through Kierkegaard, Le Guin, Dostoevsky and Girard. Chapter Five reads the *ka-tet* as an ontology of the host, through Du Bois, Morrison, Heidegger and Nancy. Chapter Six reads Roland's biography as trauma and individuation, through Freud, Lacan and Jung's alchemy. Chapter Seven reads the author's entry into the fiction as a kenosis rather than an apotheosis. Chapter Eight situates the cycle among speculative fictions and proposes a typology of centers. Chapter Nine states five theses and a corollary formally and answers the strongest objections to them. The Conclusion rereads the first sentence in the light the whole argument casts back upon it.

The claim toward which everything tends may be stated in advance. *The Dark Tower* is a **katechontic romance**: a quest-romance whose success consists not in the attainment of its object but in the restraint of its own completion; whose center must be kept empty by those who love it; and whose ethics, accordingly, is not ascent but convocation—the summoning of a host around a hub that no one may occupy.

1 *Chapter One*

Slug-Horn and Olifant

A Genealogy of the Quest



Every source from which King built the cycle narrates a quest that fails at, or cannot pass through, its center. Read in sequence, the sources compose a single inherited problem—how a quester may approach a center that will not receive him—which the cycle takes up whole and, as the later chapters argue, converts from a failure into a cosmology.

1.1 *Childe Rowland and the widershins threshold*

The oldest stratum is a Scottish tale that Robert Jamieson recalled hearing as a boy from a country tailor and printed in *Illustrations of Northern Antiquities* (1814); Joseph Jacobs reworked it as "Childe Rowland" in *English Fairy Tales* (1890). Burd Ellen, chasing a ball, runs round a church "widershins"—against the course of the sun—and vanishes into Elfland. Her two elder brothers seek her and are lost. The youngest, Childe Rowland, receives from his mother his father's brand "that never struck in vain" and from the Warlock Merlin two prohibitions: he must strike off the head of whoever speaks to him in Elfland until he finds his sister, and he must neither eat nor drink there. He beheads a horse-herd, a cow-herd and a hen-wife; he circles a round green hill three times widershins until a door opens; he refuses the bread his enchanted sister offers; he defeats the King of Elfland and redeems his siblings (Jacobs 1890).

The tale bequeaths the cycle three structures. First, the other world is opened by circling, not by ascent. Burd Ellen's counter-solar circuit is the original transgression and Rowland's repetition of it the original rescue, so that the loop precedes the Tower in the cycle's deepest source and is already ambivalent—perdition and redemption by the same movement. Second, Merlin's prohibition institutes an ethic of lethal isolation in which every interlocutor is an obstacle. The early Roland, who exterminates the town of Tull and lets Jake fall, is Merlin's instruction become a character, and the cycle's moral history is the slow repudiation of that instruction. Third, the father's sword: Roland's revolvers, whose barrels the cycle's lore declares forged from the steel of Arthur Eld's Excalibur, carry the paternal weapon of romance into the Western (Grade B).

The tale reached English literature, and so Browning and King, through a madman's song. In *King Lear*, Edgar—disinherited, disguised as Poor Tom—splices the chivalric fragment onto the ogre's rhyme: "Child Rowland to the dark tower came; / His word was still, 'Fie, foh, and fum, / I smell the blood of a British man' " (III.iv). The line is born in disinheritance and derangement, and Roland Deschain, disinherited heir of a fallen Gilead, is in literary lineage Edgar's son. The same play supplies, in the mouth of Edgar's dying half-brother, the cycle's master figure in eight words: "The wheel is come full circle; I am here" (V.iii). The circuit completed, the self discovered at its end: Edmund states the ending of *The Dark Tower* nearly four centuries before it was written.

1.2 *Browning and the ruined quest*

Browning, by his own later account, wrote "Childe Roland to the Dark Tower Came" in a single day in Paris in January 1852, and published it in *Men and Women* (1855): thirty-four six-line stanzas, rhymed *abbaab*, spoken by a knight who crosses a blasted plain on directions given by a "hoary cripple, with mali-

cious eye" whom he believes to be lying (st. I) (Grade A). Four features of the poem pass into the cycle. The first is the quester's ambivalence toward his own success:

> For, what with my whole world-wide wandering,
> What with my search drawn out thro' years, my hope
> Dwindled into a ghost not fit to cope
> With that obstreperous joy success would bring,
> I hardly tried now to rebuke the spring
> My heart made, finding failure in its scope. (st. IV)

A quester whose identity has become the search cannot survive arrival; failure is what his heart leaps toward. The stanza is the psychological seed of the loop.

The second is the gallery of disgraced peers. Browning's knight recalls Cuthbert, with his "reddening face / Beneath its garniture of curly gold," lost to "one night's disgrace" (st. XVI), and Giles, "the soul of honour," to whose breast a hangman pins a parchment: "Poor traitor, spit upon and curst!" (st. XVII). King splits and redistributes the pair. Cuthbert Allgood becomes Roland's laughing companion; the hanged traitor becomes Hax, the cook whose treason the boys Roland and Cuthbert overhear and whose execution they witness (TG).

The third is the Tower itself, which Browning renders not as a goal but as a blindness: "The round squat turret, blind as the fool's heart, / Built of brown stone, without a counterpart / In the whole world" (st. XXXI). The knight fails even to recognize it—"Dunce, / Dotard, a-dozing at the very nonce, / After a life spent training for the sight!" (st. XXX). A center without counterpart, which a whole life has trained one to see and which one does not see: here, already, is a hub rather than a destination.

The fourth is the ending, which stops at the threshold. The knight hears "Names in my ears / Of all the lost adventurers my peers" (st. XXXIII), sees them "ranged along the hill-sides, met / To view the last of me, a living frame / For one more picture," and then: "Dauntless the slug-horn to my lips I set, / And blew. 'Childe Roland to the Dark Tower came' " (st. XXXIV). The poem ends with an utterance, not an entry; what the blast accomplishes is not narrated. King literalizes the roll-call: approaching the Tower across the field of roses, Roland calls aloud the names of his dead (DT). But he does not blow the horn, because—as the closing pages disclose—he let the Horn of Eld lie in the dust of Jericho Hill beside Cuthbert's body. Browning's Childe arrives horn in hand; King's Roland arrives without it. To arrive as Browning's knight arrived, he must go round again. The loop, read genealogically, is the price of the unblown horn—a proposition Chapter Nine formalizes as Olifantine Repetition.

Bloom's reading of the poem supplies the theory. In *Poetry and Repression* the Childe's quest is "ruined" in a precise sense: the blasted landscape is the

product of his own imagination, the peers are the precursors who failed before him, and the blast is a good moment of self-naming wrested from belatedness (Bloom 1976). In "The Internalization of Quest-Romance" the Romantic quest turns inward, its adversary the quester's own Selfhood (Bloom 1969). King's summit literalizes Bloom with an almost diagrammatic fidelity: the rooms of the Tower contain nothing but Roland's past, and the precursor he meets at the top is himself.

1.3 *The olifant and the refused call*

The *Chanson de Roland* (Oxford, Bodleian MS Digby 23, c. 1100) is the text of the olifant (Grade B). Surrounded at Roncevaux, Roland three times refuses Oliver's plea to sound the horn and recall Charlemagne; to call for help would shame his lineage. The poem compresses its judgment into a line: "Rollant est proz e Oliver est sage" (l. 1093)—Roland is valiant, Oliver wise. When the rear-guard is dying Roland at last blows, so hard that his temples burst; and Oliver's reproach names the missing virtue: "Mielz valt mesure que ne fait estultie" (l. 1725)—measure is worth more than rashness. *Mesure*, limit, is precisely what the Tower will impose upon the second Roland. The two heroes share one fault, the pride that will not summon the host, and differ in its consequence. The first Roland blows too late; the second does not blow at all, and is returned by the Tower to a point at which blowing is again possible. Cuthbert—loyal, mocking, the last bearer of the Horn—is Roland's Oliver in function if not in temperament.

1.4 *Arthur Eld and the problem of Mordred*

Malory's *Le Morte Darthur* (Caxton, 1485) supplies both ancestor and nemesis (Grade A/B). Warned by Merlin that a child born on May-day will destroy him, Arthur has the May-born children of the realm put to sea in a ship; the ship founders, and Mordred alone—Arthur's son by his half-sister—survives to kill his father at Camlann. Two correspondences follow. The ruler who purchases the kingdom's safety with its children anticipates the Calla's tribute (Chapter Four), so that King's Arthurian inheritance includes not only Excalibur's steel but the Herodian logic of sacrificing the young to cheat a prophecy. And the fatal son begotten through transgression returns in Mordred Deschain. In TG Roland lies with the Oracle, a succubus of a speaking ring, as the price of her prophecy, and she keeps his seed. In WL, at another speaking ring, Susannah lets Detta come forward to hold the ring's demon off by sex while Eddie and Roland bring Jake through the door; the scene is written as an assault and widely read as a rape, and through this demon the seed the Oracle took from Roland passes into her. The Crimson King supplies a second paternity

(SoS; DT). Malory's fatality is raised to metaphysics: hero and destroyer are co-parents of the thing that will destroy the hero. Chapter Nine takes this double paternity as the decisive evidence for Centripetal Usurpation.

1.5 *The Grail and the unasked question*

In Chrétien's *Perceval* (c. 1180–1190) the young knight, schooled by Gornemant to curb his tongue, watches the Grail procession in the castle of the maimed Fisher King and fails to ask whom the Grail serves; the king stays wounded and the land waste. In Wolfram's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210) the question becomes ethical—"œheim, waz wirret dir?" ("Uncle, what ails you?," 795.29)—and its asking heals Anfortas. Wagner's *Parsifal* (1882) condenses the tradition into its oracle: *durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor*, made knowing through compassion, the pure fool (Grade B). The Grail matter gives the cycle its moral axis: the difference between the quest for an object and the question put to a sufferer. The early Roland is a Perceval who will not ask; the Calla, where he must learn what ails a town, is the Grail castle in which he learns to ask. And from the opening of DoT he is also the Fisher King: on the shore of the Western Sea the lobstrosities take two fingers of his right hand and a toe, maiming him in the organ of his office and rendering him dependent on others for healing (Chapter Five).

1.6 *Eliot's tarot and the missing card*

King titles WL after Eliot's poem and names its first two books from its lines, "Fear in a Handful of Dust" and "A Heap of Broken Images" (Grade A). The debt is structural. Madame Sosostris's pack (*The Waste Land*, ll. 43–59) is the model for the reading the man in black gives Roland at the Golgotha: the Hanged Man, the Sailor, the Prisoner, the Lady of Shadows, Death, and at last the Tower (TG). Sosostris confesses, "I do not find / The Hanged Man" (ll. 54–55); Walter turns him up first. King supplies Eliot's missing card, and supplies it as his hero. Eliot's note associates the Hanged Man with Frazer's hanged god and with "the hooded figure in the passage of the disciples to Emmaus in Part V"—the passage that asks, "Who is the third who walks always beside you?" (l. 359). WL contains a boy who both did and did not die, walking as a third in Roland's divided memory until the paradox is resolved by drawing him bodily through a door: Jake is Eliot's third, the Hanged Man's companion.

The lesser correspondences are as exact. "We think of the key, each in his prison / Thinking of the key, each confirms a prison" (ll. 413–414): Eddie, dealt as the Prisoner, carves the key that admits Jake, reversing Eliot's despair into craft. "London Bridge is falling down falling down falling down" (l. 427): Lud—whose name recalls the King Lud from whom Geoffrey of Monmouth

derived London—is a ruined city entered by a failing bridge. "Falling towers / Jerusalem Athens Alexandria / Vienna London / Unreal" (ll. 373–376) is the cycle's multiverse in miniature. "I sat upon the shore / Fishing, with the arid plain behind me" (ll. 424–425) is the tableau with which DoT opens. The thunder's *Datta, Dayadhvam, Damyata*—give, sympathize, control, from the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* (V.2)—is the moral grammar of the middle volumes: Jake's giving, the Calla's sympathy, Roland's self-command. And "These fragments I have shored against my ruins" (l. 431) is the motto of King's method (§1.9).

1.7 *Tolkien, Leone, Ford, Kurosawa*

In the foreword to the revised TG, "On Being Nineteen," King traces the cycle to a conjunction of his late adolescence: Tolkien's trilogy and Leone's *The Good, the Bad and the Ugly* (1966), and the desire to write a long novel joining Tolkien's sense of quest and magic to Leone's almost absurdly majestic western landscape—without, he adds, hobbits (paraphrased; Grade A). The synthesis is genre-theoretical. The fairy-tale quest is teleological, ordered to an object to be won or destroyed; the Western is circular, the drifter arriving, redeeming a town he cannot join, and departing. *The Dark Tower* is the collision of a teleology with a circle, and its ending is what that collision produces.

Leone contributes more than the Eastwood silhouette on which King modeled the early Roland. *The Good, the Bad and the Ugly* ends in a three-way duel in the circular stone plaza at the heart of Sad Hill cemetery, organized around a stone set at the center of the ring on whose underside the decisive name is said to be written—and from which, in the event, no name is ever read; the treasure itself lies under a marker reading "Unknown" (Grade C). A showdown ordered around a center that withholds the name is a Western emblem of kenotic axiality. *Once Upon a Time in the West* (1968) contributes a form: the hero's trauma withheld in fragmentary flashback until the climax discloses it, as WG withholds Roland's primal scene until the fourth volume. Ford's *The Searchers* (1956) contributes the cycle's last image before the loop: Ethan Edwards restores the stolen girl to the family and remains outside as the door closes on the domestic interior—the frontier hero enables the community he cannot enter. Kurosawa's *Seven Samurai* (1954), remade by John Sturges as *The Magnificent Seven* (1960), is the template of WC, whose Calla Bryn Sturgis is widely read as a nod to Sturges; Kambei's closing judgment that the farmers, not the samurai, have won assigns the victory to the host.

1.8 *Bunyan's two pilgrimages and Wolfe's unfound door*

Bunyan's first part (1678) purchases the vertical pilgrimage by horizontal abandonment: Christian's wife and children cry after him to return, "but the Man put his fingers in his Ears, and ran on crying, Life, Life, Eternal Life." The second part (1684) rewrites the first as a communal journey, Christiana following with her children and neighbours under the guidance of Great-heart (Grade B). *The Dark Tower* contains both parts. Roland's pilgrimage is Christian's; Susannah's departure through the drawn door into a world where Eddie and Jake await her is Christiana's; the Coda's two endings are Bunyan's two parts, set side by side and left for the reader to weigh.

Thomas Wolfe's *Look Homeward, Angel* (1929) opens with the lament from which King drew a refrain: "a stone, a leaf, an unfound door; of a stone, a leaf, a door. And of all the forgotten faces." King's version, sounding through WL and after, replaces the leaf with a rose (Grade A). The substitution is exact: Wolfe's emblem of seasonal passing becomes the cosmological emblem of the Tower's other form (Chapter Two). And Wolfe's forgotten faces return, inverted, in the gunslinger's catechism, whose sin is to have "forgotten the face of his father": an elegy of exile becomes an ethic of memory (Chapter Three).

1.9 *Bricolage and the self-precursor*

Lévi-Strauss describes the *bricoleur* as one who builds from the odds and ends left over by earlier constructions, each fragment retaining traces of its former use (Lévi-Strauss 1962). King's bricolage is notorious: the ruby slippers of MGM's film rather than the silver shoes of Baum's novel in WG's Green Palace; the great bear of Richard Adams's *Shardik* (1974) as a Guardian of the Beam; Lovecraft's Old Ones; Asimov's positronics in North Central Positronics; Wolves in masks resembling Marvel's Doctor Doom, armed with light-sticks and with grenades bearing a Harry Potter model designation; a ZZ Top drum track as the god-drums of Lud. These are not lapses of taste but the ontology of a world that "has moved on." Mid-World is built from our debris, as Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980) builds post-nuclear Kent from ours; its inhabitants know their sacred objects only as fragments whose former use is lost, and the reader is invited to recognize, in the fragments, the culture that broke them.

The final stratum of the genealogy is King himself. Bloom's sixth revisionary ratio, *apophrades* or the return of the dead, names the late phase in which a strong poet holds his work so open to the precursor that the precursor seems to have been written by the successor (Bloom 1973). The revision of TG in 2003—the King of his mid-fifties rewriting the King of his twenties and early thirties to harmonize the first volume's diction, geography and cosmology with the last—is *apophrades* practised upon oneself: the late author made his origin look like his

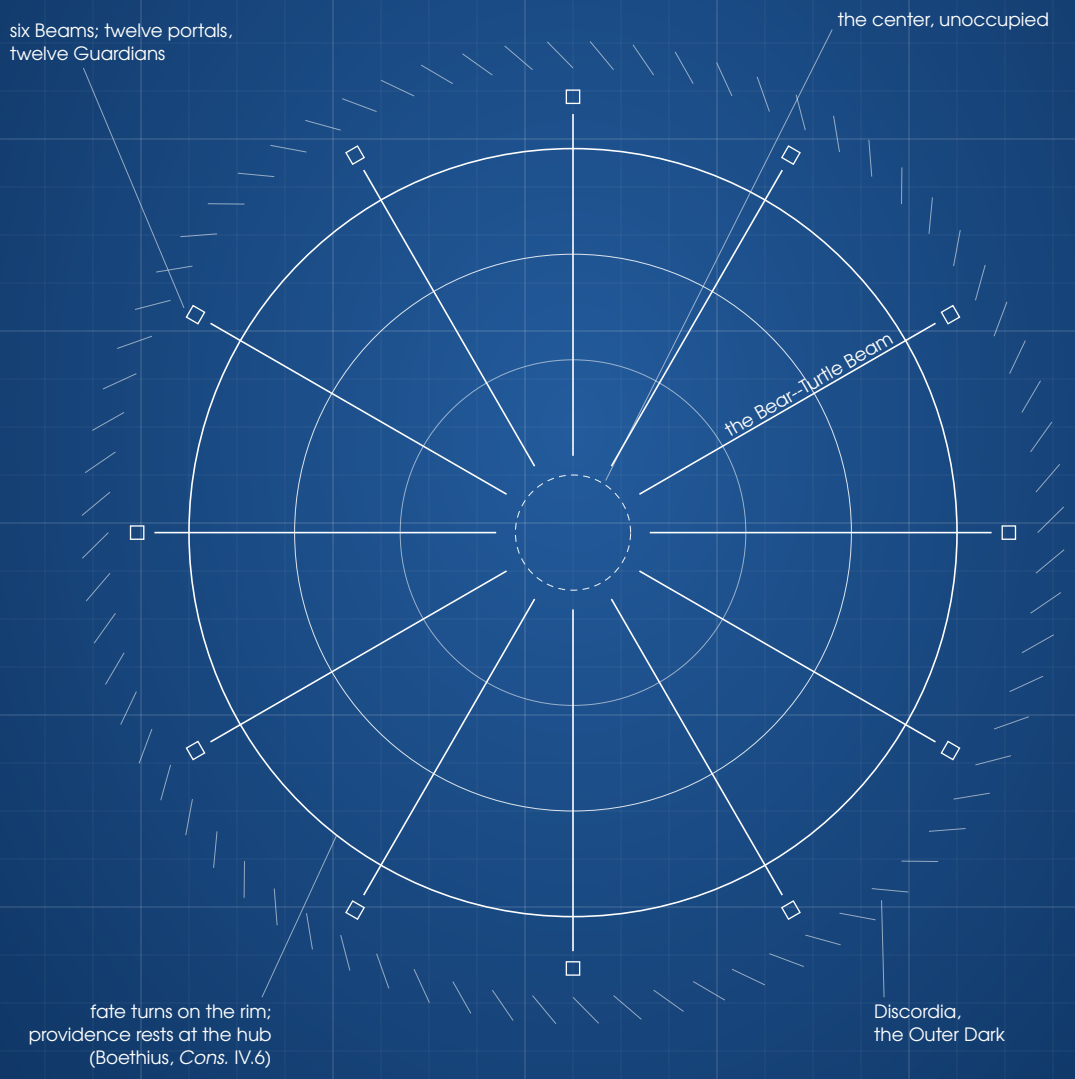
end. The loop was enacted at the level of composition before it was published as plot.

The genealogy thus closes on a finding. Every source King chose narrates a center that cannot be passed: a hill opened only by circling it against the sun, a turret blind as the fool's heart, a horn blown too late, a question unasked, a card the fortune-teller cannot find, a family abandoned for eternal life, a door closed upon the hero. *The Dark Tower* is the summa of these ruined centers. The chapters that follow argue that it does not merely collect them; it converts their ruin into a positive theory of what a center is.

2 *Chapter Two*

Ka Is a Wheel

A Cosmology of the Empty Hub



The cycle's cosmology is organized around a center that sustains everything by containing nothing. The Tower holds the worlds because it is held by the Beams, and its interior holds only the past of whoever climbs it. This chapter reconstructs that cosmology and returns its figures to their philosophical originators.

The Hub and the Host

Sheet 2 of 10

2.1 *Prim, Gan and Discordia: an emanationist cosmogony*

In the cosmogony the late volumes assemble (DT; cf. Furth 2012), all things arise from the Prim, a primordial sea of undifferentiated magic. From it come Gan, the creative force the cycle half-personifies as a god, and—upon the Prim's recession—the Tower and its Beams, the architecture of existence. Beneath and around them persists Discordia, the chaotic residue: the Outer Dark, and the todash spaces between worlds where hungry things wait. The cosmogony is emanationist rather than creationist. The Tower is not made; it stands.

Three ancient schemes clarify the structure (Grade C). Hesiod's Chaos—"ἤτοι μὲν πρώτιστα Χάος γένετ'" (*Theogony* 116), "first of all Chaos came to be"—is a yawning gap rather than disorder, the opening in which things can appear. Empedocles's alternation of Love and Strife, uniting and dividing the elements in turn, supplies the dynamic of a cosmos perpetually made and unmade. Plotinus's procession from the One, with matter as the privative darkness at the far edge of emanation, supplies the ontology of Discordia most exactly: not a rival principle but a lack, a privation that the Crimson King, its servant, would make total. The Valentinian opposition of *plērōma* (fullness) and *kenōma* (emptiness) completes the frame, and will return in Chapter Nine.

2.2 *The prosthetic cosmos of the Old Ones*

The magic that raised the Beams faded, and the Old People—a vanished technological civilization whose ruins litter Mid-World—replaced it with machines built by firms such as North Central Positronics and LaMerk Industries (DT). The Beams became infrastructure. Machines fail; the Beams weakened; and the Crimson King set captive psychics, the Breakers, to erode what remained. The cosmos of the late cycle is thus prosthetic: a given structure replaced by an owned one.

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) names the essence of modern technology *Gestell*, enframing, a mode of revealing that challenges nature forth and orders it as *Bestand*, standing-reserve; his example is the Rhine, dammed into a power plant and so revealed as a supplier of energy. The Beams under the Old Ones are exactly this: a cosmic order converted into supply. Nor does enframing stop at nature. The Breakers are human standing-reserve, and the twins of the Calla—whose brains yield the substance fed to the Breakers to amplify their work (WC; DT)—are standing-reserve for standing-reserve. Heidegger's "danger," that the human being itself becomes standing-reserve, is King's apocalypse literalized. The Old Ones' sin is not technology as such but possession: the substitution of maintenance-as-ownership for reception. The concept carries its author's history. Heidegger was a member of the Nazi party from 1933 to 1945, and in a Bremen lecture of 1949 he

called motorized agriculture the same in essence as the production of corpses in gas chambers and extermination camps, dissolving the murder of Europe's Jews into a general critique of technology (Heidegger 1949). The harvested children of the Calla call for the specificity he refused: they are not an instance of enframing in general but victims, taken by the Wolves and consumed in the service of the Crimson King.

King borrowed the name "Old Ones" from Lovecraft, whose *At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) imagines a vanished technological race undone by the servants it engineered, and he inverted its moral (Grade A). Lovecraft's Old Ones are inhuman and the horror is cosmic indifference; King's Old Ones are us, and the horror is our industry.

2.3 *The Beams and their Guardians*

Six Beams run through the Tower, each terminating at two portals kept by animal Guardians—twelve in all, among them Shardik the Bear and Maturin the Turtle, along whose Beam the ka-tet travels. The Turtle carries a pan-cultural resonance: Kūrma, the tortoise avatar of Viṣṇu who bears the churning-mountain; Akūpāra, the world-turtle; the Turtle Island of Lenape and Haudenosaunee cosmology; and, within King's own corpus, the ancient Turtle of *It* (1986), which the novel credits with having brought the universe forth. The Bear comes from Adams's *Shardik* (1974), a novel about a bear misread as a god, whose cult culminates in cruelty—including a traffic in enslaved children—and whose protagonist is redeemed only when he renounces theocratic power to shelter children like those the slavers traded (Grade A). The Guardians stand at the ends of the Beams, not at their crossing. King's cosmology places its visible sacredness on the circumference and leaves the center dark.

2.4 *Axis mundi and the inversion of Babel*

Eliade's morphology of the sacred (1949; 1957) identifies the symbolism of the center—mountain, pillar, tree, ladder—as the connection of heaven, earth and underworld, re-founded at every sacred site: Jacob's ladder at Bethel, where the patriarch wakes to say, "this is none other but the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven" (Gen. 28:17); Yggdrasil; Mount Meru. René Guénon's *Le Symbolisme de la croix* (1931) locates the center at the intersection of the cross's arms, the "invariable middle" unaffected by the rotation it governs. The Tower, rising from its field of roses at the crossing of the Beams, is the textbook *axis mundi* (Grade B/C). Eliade's own history belongs on the record: in 1937–38 he wrote in support of Romania's fascist and antisemitic Iron Guard, a decade before the books cited here (Ellwood 1999). The figure of the center is used in this study for its structure, with that history noted.

It is also an inverted Babel. "Go to, let us build us a city and a tower, whose top may reach unto heaven; and let us make us a name, lest we be scattered abroad upon the face of the whole earth" (Gen. 11:4). Babel is a tower built to make a name and to prevent scattering, and its punishment is scattering and the confusion of names. King's Tower is found, not built. At its summit the climber finds his own name on the door, and opening it scatters him—not across space but back across time, to the desert. Babel's ambition is fulfilled and its punishment repeated in a single gesture: the name is attained only at the price of being sent back. To reach the top is to meet one's name, and one's name returns one to the beginning.

A further resonance illuminates the cycle's key terms without any claim of influence (Grade C). The Egyptian *ka*, the vital double of the person, is shown in the divine-birth reliefs of Hatshepsut's temple at Deir el-Bahari being fashioned by the ram-headed Khnum on a potter's wheel alongside the royal body: in Egyptian iconography the *ka* is literally made on a wheel. And the *tyet*, the knot of Isis, is paired throughout Egyptian amuletic and architectural ornament with the *djed*, the pillar of Osiris that signifies stability. Pillar and knot, axis and binding: the hieroglyphic pair is the hub-and-host figure that King names, by accident or intuition, *ka* and *ka-tet*.

2.5 *The Rose*

In the Keystone World the Tower has a second body: a single wild rose in a vacant lot at Second Avenue and 46th Street in Manhattan, whose humming draws Jake (WL). Four traditions converge upon it (Grade B/C). Dante's *candida rosa* (*Par.* XXX–XXXI), the white rose of the blessed ranked in tiers about the light, is the celestial host figured as petals around a luminous center; King's Rose is the Tower in its host-form, a multiplicity folded about a heart. Yeats's "To the Rose upon the Rood of Time" (1892)—"Red Rose, proud Rose, sad Rose of all my days! / Come near me, while I sing the ancient ways"—invokes the Rosicrucian emblem of the rose upon the cross, the device of the *Fama Fraternitatis* (1614) and the *Chymical Wedding* (1616); King's Tower, standing at the crossing of the Beams, is a rose upon a rood. Blake's "The Sick Rose" (1794) supplies the adversary's figure: "O Rose thou art sick. / The invisible worm, / That flies in the night / In the howling storm: / Has found out thy bed / Of crimson joy: / And his dark secret love / Does thy life destroy." The canker that seeks the bed of crimson joy is an emblem, if not a source, of the Crimson King's relation to the Rose. And Blake's "dark Satanic Mills" name the cycle's industrial villains with uncanny precision: Mills Construction and the Sombra Corporation, whose sign on the lot's fence announces luxury condominiums at Turtle Bay (WL). The Rose is threatened not by sorcery but by real estate.

That threat recasts the cosmology in the idiom of political economy. The vacant lot is the last commons of the cosmos, and its enclosure is the cycle's version of what Marx called primitive accumulation, the expropriation of the commons that precedes capital (*Capital* I, part 8). Eco's *The Name of the Rose* (1980) closes on a line from Bernard of Cluny, *stat rosa pristina nomine, nomina nuda tenemus*—the rose of old stands only in its name; we hold bare names. King's Rose, by contrast, survives as a thing that must be kept unowned, and the cycle's defense of it—the Tet Corporation's purchase of the lot—protects a commons by owning it, a paradox Chapter Nine confronts. In the Rose's final setting, a small garden at the foot of a tower the cycle calls 2 Hammarskjöld Plaza (DT), Manhattan's own geography supplies a last resonance: Dag Hammarskjöld, whose name the plaza bears, left in *Vägmärken* (*Markings*, 1963) a mystical diary of self-surrender in public office—a kenosis of power in the service of a world order (Grade C).

2.6 *The empty hub*

The philosophical core of the cosmology is a single figure, a center whose function is its emptiness, and it appears independently in at least six traditions (Grade C). The first is Laozi's (*Daodejing* 11): "Thirty spokes share a single hub; in its nothing lies the use of the cart. Knead clay into a vessel; in its nothing lies the use of the vessel. Cut doors and windows for a room; in its nothing lies the use of the room. So: what is there gives profit; what is not there gives use." The second is Zhuangzi's (ch. 2): "Where 'this' and 'that' cease to find their opposites is called the pivot of the Way. Only when the pivot finds the center of the ring can it respond without end." The pivot in the ring's center is a point of non-partiality from which all things are answered.

The third is Boethius's. Providence stands to fate as the center of a circle to its circumference: *ut … ad punctum medium circulus, ita est fati series mobilis ad providentiae stabilem simplicitatem*, as the circle to its central point, so the moving series of fate to the stable simplicity of providence (*Cons.* IV, pr. 6). Among orbs revolving about one pivot, the innermost approaches the simplicity of the center, and the nearer anything comes to the center, the freer it is from the chain of fate. *Ka* turns on the circumference; the Tower is the point at which *ka* goes still.

The fourth is Dante's. Beatrice shows the pilgrim a point of piercing light about which nine rings of angels wheel: "Da quel punto / depende il cielo e tutta la natura" (*Par.* XXVIII.41–42), from that point hang the heavens and all nature—a translation of Aristotle's unmoved mover (*Metaph.* Λ.7, 1072b13–14). The point is extensionless: the source of all motion, itself unmoved and unoccupied. Mark A. Peterson (1979) showed that Dante's cosmos is consistent with a three-sphere, in which the two "centers"—the earth, with Lucifer at its core,

and the divine point—are antipodes; to ascend through the spheres to the point is to find it surrounding everything, the center become circumference.

The fifth is Isaac Luria's, as reconstructed by Scholem (1941; 1974). Creation begins with *tzimtzum*, the withdrawal of the Infinite from a point in order to make a space for finite being; the vessels that received the returning light shattered (*shevirat ha-kelim*); and the work of creatures is *tikkun*, repair. The Tower's darkness is the darkness of *tzimtzum*, the withdrawal that lets worlds be; the Breakers are the breaking; the labors of the ka-tet are the *tikkun*. The sixth is Paul's: the Son "emptied himself" (ἑαυτὸν ἐκένωσεν), taking the form of a servant (Phil. 2:7), so that divine power manifests as self-evacuation. A seventh, political rather than theological, is Claude Lefort's: in modern democracy the place of power becomes an empty place, which no one may occupy as its substance, and totalitarianism is the attempt to fill it (Lefort 1981; 1986).

The convergence licenses a proposition that the cycle's details confirm. The Tower's darkness is not malevolence but reticence. Its interior contains no god, no throne and no oracle—only rooms displaying relics of the climber's own life, and at the top a door bearing his name (DT). The Tower sustains the worlds by not intervening in them; it appears dark because it withholds itself. This is the first datum of Thesis I.

2.7 *Ka is a wheel*

The cycle's maxim that "ka is a wheel" condenses a long genealogy of fate as rotation. Boethius's Fortuna turns her wheel and delights in carrying the lowest to the summit and the summit to the depths (*Cons.* II, pr. 2); medieval iconography inscribed its quarters *regnabo, regno, regnavi, sum sine regno*—I shall reign, I reign, I have reigned, I am without reign. On Fortune's wheel summit and fall are positions on one rotation: whoever climbs to the top is necessarily carried down. The Buddhist *bhavacakra*, the wheel of becoming held in the jaws of Yama, places at its hub the three poisons—a pig, a cock and a snake, delusion, craving and aversion—each biting the tail of the next: *saṃsāra* is a wheel whose hub is occupied. King's wheel is the inverse. Its hub must be kept empty, and the Crimson King is the power that would install the poisons at the center.

The Stoic *heimarmenē*, the chain of causes, and Nietzsche's *amor fati* (*Gay Science* §276) supply the ethics of the rim. *Insomnia* supplies the cycle's own theology of fate: the Purpose, served by Clotho and Lachesis, and the Random, served by Atropos (Ins). *Ka* is Purpose experienced from the circumference. This theology makes King's cosmos anti-Lovecraftian. Lovecraft's universe is indifferent, and its horror is the discovery of meaninglessness; King's contains horror in abundance—the todash demons, the Outer Dark—but it is providential. The Beam can be served, the Rose sings, and the voice of the Beam can be

heard by a writer in Maine. The horror is not that the center is empty. It is that someone might fill it.

2.8 *Keystone and nineteen*

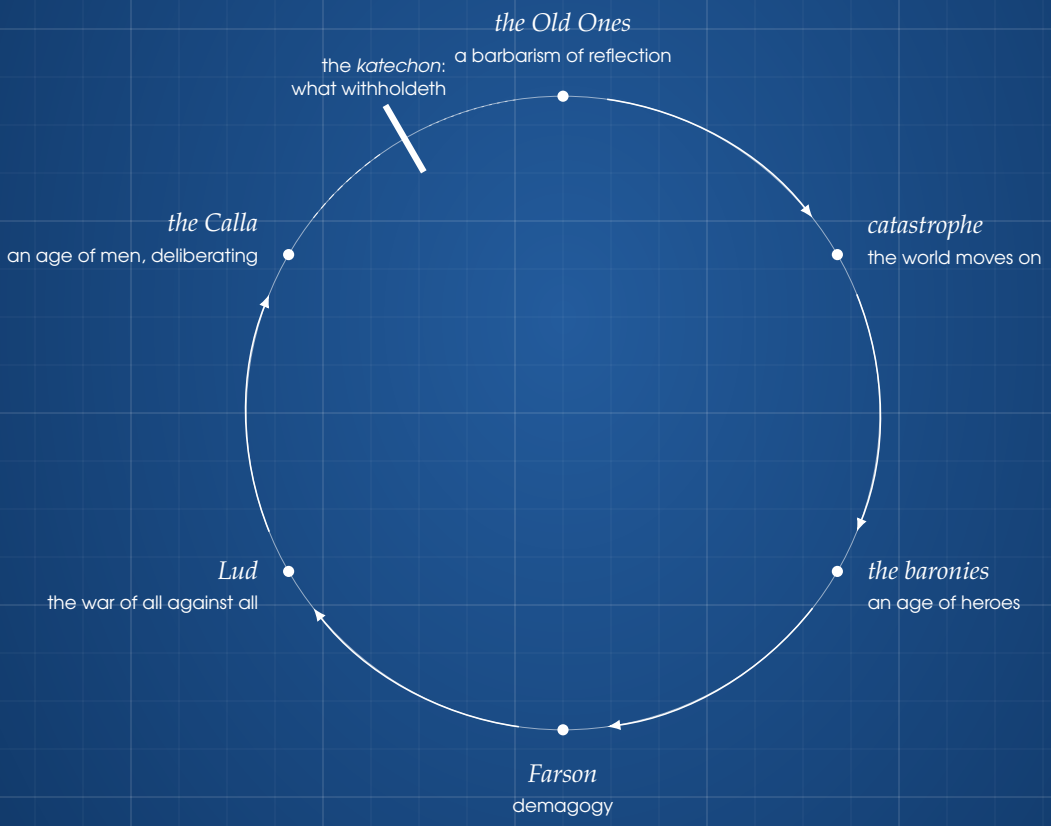
Our world, in the cycle's vocabulary, is the Keystone World. The architectural metaphor is precise. An arch stands because each voussoir leans upon its neighbors; the keystone locks the arch but is itself held by the stones it locks; no stone is *the* support, and the arch is a relation rather than a thing. Nāgārjuna states the same insight as a metaphysics: whatever arises dependently is, for that very reason, empty, and emptiness is itself a dependent designation (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 24.18; trans. Garfield 1995). The Tower is a keystone in this sense: it holds the Beams only as the Beams hold it. Its primacy is relational, which is the premise of Thesis II.

The late volumes are saturated with the number nineteen—in dates (the accident of 19 June 1999), in names and in the counting of letters. The number has an old cosmological sense that the cycle never mentions (Grade C). Nineteen solar years make the Metonic cycle, after which the phases of the moon recur on the same calendar days; the medieval *numerus aureus*, a year's position within that cycle, was the key of the *computus* by which the date of Easter was fixed. Nineteen is the arithmetic of recurrence and, in the Christian calendar, the calculation of resurrection. The cipher King chose for his cycle is the ancient number of a return that is also a rising.

3 *Chapter Three*

The Line of Eld

Political Theology and the Katechon



after Polybius VI and Vico's ricorso

The gunslingers are a katechontic order: a caste whose historical function is to restrain the end rather than to redeem the world. The cycle's politics turns on the discovery that the restraining power is structurally akin to the lawlessness it restrains, so that only a horizontal, convoked restraint can hold without becoming what it holds back.

3.1 Gilead and the Affiliation

Roland's home is Gilead, the chief barony of In-World, ruled by descendants of Arthur Eld and policed by the gunslingers, a knightly caste of lawmen within the alliance of baronies called the Affiliation. The name carries two biblical charges (Grade B). "Is there no balm in Gilead; is there no physician there?" (Jer. 8:22) makes Gilead the place of healing whose absence is lamented; and Galeed, the "heap of witness" where Jacob and Laban raise a cairn to seal a boundary covenant (Gen. 31:47–48), makes it the place where a limit is sworn before God. Roland's Gilead is both and neither: a polity of balm and boundary that falls, within his youth, to the insurgency of John Farson, "the Good Man," a populist who promises liberation from aristocracy and delivers terror. There is no balm in Gilead, and the heap of witness is scattered.

3.2 Cort, David and the rite of succession

Apprenticeship in Gilead ends in single combat with the teacher, Cort, fought with a weapon of the candidate's choosing. Roland, fourteen, provoked into premature trial by the sight of his mother with the court sorcerer Marten, chooses his hawk, David; the hawk dies and the boy wins (TG). The rite is the one Frazer made famous in *The Golden Bough*: the priest-king of Nemi, who holds office until slain by his successor, and whose condition Frazer framed with Macaulay's lines, "The priest who slew the slayer, / And shall himself be slain" (Grade B). Gilead's order is founded on ritual succession by combat, what Walter Benjamin would call mythic violence, the violence that founds law and then preserves it (Benjamin 1921).

The hawk, named for the boy who slew Goliath, is Roland's first instrumentalized companion. The gunslinger becomes a man by spending a friend, and the pattern set here governs the cycle: each stage of Roland's advance is paid for in companions. Yeats's "The Second Coming" (1920) supplies the political emblem: "Turning and turning in the widening gyre / The falcon cannot hear the falconer; / Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold; / Mere anarchy is loosed upon the world." Falconry is the relation of command that binds servant to master across open air, and Gilead is a falconer's polity. When the falcon drifts beyond the call the center cannot hold; the widening gyre, an expanding spiral, is the loop's political form. Roland's first act of manhood breaks the bond from the other side, by killing the falcon.

3.3 The face of the father

The gunslinger's catechism declares that he who aims with his hand has "forgotten the face of his father" (TG); the gunslinger aims instead with his eye,

shoots with his mind and kills with his heart. The formula inverts Levinas with startling exactness. For Levinas the face of the other signifies, prior to any law, the command not to kill (Levinas 1961). In Gilead the face—the father's—is remembered in order to kill well: the paternal face becomes the source not of the prohibition of murder but of its discipline. Lacan's Name-of-the-Father, the paternal signifier through which law enters desire, is here a law of lethal accuracy (Grade C).

Roland's father is Steven Deschain. The homonymy with Stephen King is inert in 1982 and retroactively charged in 2004, when the author enters the fiction (SoS; DT). The face the gunslinger must not forget is, at the metafictional level, the face of the one who writes him. The creed thus commands fidelity to the author—an injunction Chapter Seven reads as the political theology of authorship.

3.4 *Hamlet and Orestes without an Areopagus*

Gabrielle Deschain's affair with Marten Broadcloak, the counselor later known as Walter, while Steven is absent, reproduces Hamlet's constellation: the absent father, the mother's betrayal with a usurping counselor, the son's delayed and ambivalent vengeance. In WG the constellation becomes the Oresteia's. Roland kills his mother, deceived by the witch Rhea's glamour into seeing a serpent where Gabrielle holds a gift she has made for him. Aeschylus ends his trilogy with the Areopagus: the vendetta is interrupted by an institution, the court of Athena, and the Furies are persuaded to become the Kindly Ones (*Eumenides*). Gilead never convenes an Areopagus. Its only law is the gun and its only judgment the duel; the matricide goes to no court, and the Furies, unpersuaded, follow Roland into every subsequent volume.

The cycle's nearest approach to an Areopagus lies not in Gilead but in the Calla. Tian Jaffords summons the farmers to a town meeting to decide whether to resist the Wolves (WC), and there the gunslinger cannot command. He must persuade, and—in the cycle's most extraordinary political scene—he must dance (§9.8). The meeting is the New England township transposed to Mid-World, the institution Tocqueville called a primary school of freedom, in which citizens learn self-government by exercising it (Tocqueville 1835–40). The ka-tet's own name for itself, "one made from many," is the motto of the American union, *e pluribus unum*. The Calla, not Gilead, is where the cycle's political hope resides: a deliberative assembly that convokes armed strangers without ceding its sovereignty to them.

3.5 *The exception at Tull*

In Tull the preacher Sylvia Pittston names Roland the Interloper and the Antichrist and incites her congregation against him; Roland kills every inhabitant of the town, including his lover Allie (TG). Carl Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception (Schmitt 1922). He joined the Nazi party in 1933, and in 1934 he defended the killings of Hitler's purge that summer as the Führer protecting the law (Schmitt 1934): the theory of the exception was put to that use by its own author. Roland at Tull is a sovereign without a state, a walking state of exception who decides who may live. Giorgio Agamben showed that sovereign and *homo sacer* are symmetrical figures at the threshold of law: the sovereign, before whom all are potentially *homines sacri*, and *homo sacer*, who may be killed by anyone without the killing counting as homicide (Agamben 1995). Roland at Tull is both at once—the Interloper whom anyone may kill, and the sovereign who kills everyone without trial. Tull is the cycle's zero point of politics, an exception with no norm left to suspend, and everything after it is Roland's slow re-entry into law.

3.6 *The katechon*

"And now ye know what withholdeth that he might be revealed in his time. For the mystery of iniquity doth already work: only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way" (2 Thess. 2:6–7). The restraining power—*to katechon* in the neuter, *ho katechōn* in the masculine—holds back the man of lawlessness, *ho anomos*, until its removal. Patristic exegesis identified it with the Roman empire, and Schmitt made the medieval Christian empire the historical *katechon*, the power whose restraint of the Antichrist prolongs history itself (Schmitt 1950) (Grade C).

The gunslingers are a katechontic order. Their office is to restrain, not to redeem; the Beams are the cosmic *katechon*; and "all things serve the Beam" is a katechontic creed. The Breakers are the anti-*katechon*, their labor hastening the end, and the Crimson King is the *anomos*. The Pauline text, however, harbors a paradox that Agamben pressed in his readings of it (2000; 2013): the restrainer and the lawless one are structurally akin, since both operate by suspending the law, and the power that holds back the climax of iniquity also prolongs its reign. The cycle feels this paradox in its bones. Roland's violence in restraint of chaos resembles chaos, as Tull shows, and his climb, pursued past the death of every companion, risks becoming the *anomos*'s own act of seizure.

The resolution the cycle reaches is a horizontal *katechon*. It is not a sovereign who restrains by exception but a host that restrains by holding: the Breakers freed at the Devar-Toi, after which the Beams begin to heal; the farmers of the Calla, and the women who throw the plates of the Sisters of Oriza; the Tet Cor-

poration guarding the Rose; a boy who dies on a Maine road to keep a writer alive (DT). Restraint passes from the gun to the convocation, and the *katechon* ceases to be an office and becomes a fellowship.

3.7 *Anacyclosis, ricorso and the ruins of Lud*

Mid-World's history is cyclical in the precise senses developed by classical political theory (Grade C). Polybius's *anacyclosis* (*Histories* VI) runs from kingship through tyranny, aristocracy, oligarchy and democracy to ochlocracy and back to monarchy. Vico's *Scienza nuova* (1725; 1744) traces the course of nations through the ages of gods, heroes and men, ending in a "barbarism of reflection" more savage than the original barbarism of sense—a civilization of refined intellect and calculated malice—from which providence returns humanity, through ruin, to primitive simplicity, and so to the *ricorso*. Mid-World runs this course. The Old Ones' hypertrophic civilization is the barbarism of reflection; its catastrophe yields the feudal heroic age of the baronies; Farson's insurgency is demagogy; Lud is degeneration; and the Calla, agrarian and deliberative, is the beginning of a new age of men.

Lud is the cycle's Hobbesian nadir (WL). Its two factions, the Pubes and the Grays, descendants of the city's old parties, are locked in perpetual civil war; when the god-drums sound through the city's speakers—a rock recording whose origin the reader recognizes and the inhabitants cannot—the Pubes draw lots and hang the loser. This is Hobbes's condition of mere nature: "no Arts; no Letters; no Society; and which is worst of all, continuall feare, and danger of violent death; And the life of man, solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short" (*Leviathan* XIII). Lud's sovereign is not a Leviathan born of covenant but Blaine, an insane machine intelligence that craves its own death and wishes to take its passengers with it. Mechanical sovereignty without covenant is the political form of the Old Ones' prosthesis.

3.8 *The Crimson King as Egocrat*

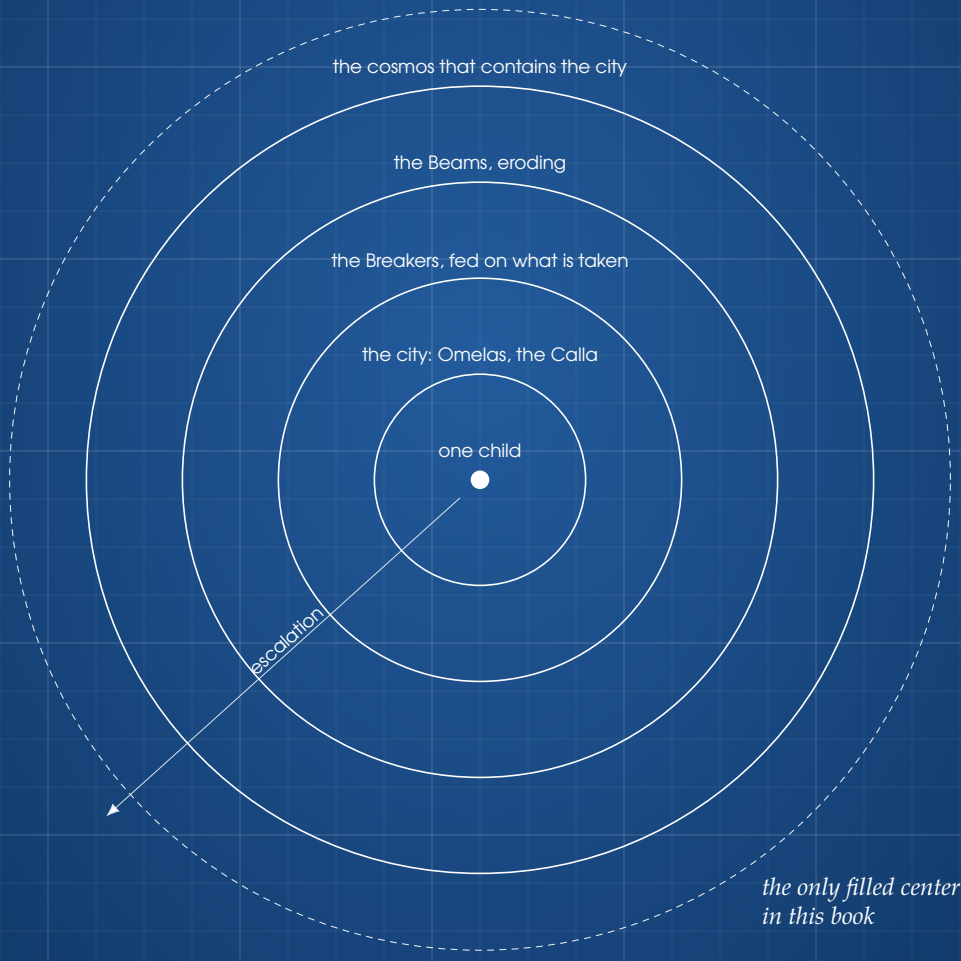
Lefort's account of totalitarianism supplies the last figure. Where democracy leaves the place of power empty, totalitarianism restores the body politic's unity by filling that place with the People-as-One, embodied in the Egocrat—the term Lefort took from Solzhenitsyn—who coincides with society and knows everything (Lefort 1981). The Crimson King, Los' the Red, is the cosmic Egocrat. Mad and solitary, he wills not to rule the Tower but to destroy it, so as to reign alone over the Discordia that would follow: the fantasy of an absolute One in a void. His final condition is exact. Trapped on a balcony of the Tower, unable to enter it, he pelts Roland with grenades from outside (DT). The would-be occupant of the center is locked out of the center he would fill, and he is defeated not by

a gun but by an artist's eraser (Chapter Seven). The political lesson is the cosmological one: the only power that can defeat the usurper of the empty place is the preservation of its emptiness.

4 *Chapter Four*

Other Worlds Than These

Sacrifice, the Scapegoat and the Price of the Beam



The cycle stages the same sacrifice twice—Jake Chambers's death for the Tower—and the difference between the two stagings is the difference between a sacrifice taken and a gift given. Between them lies an extended critique of every social order that purchases its peace with the young.

4.1 *The fall beneath the mountains*

Beneath the Cyclopean Mountains, Roland pursues the man in black across a rotting trestle above a chasm. Jake slips and hangs from the ties; Roland chooses to let him fall and to continue the chase. The boy's last words to him are "Go then, there are other worlds than these" (TG). The sentence is at once a curse, a release and a cosmological disclosure: the first announcement of the multiverse is spoken by a child at the moment of his sacrifice, so that the metaphysics of plural worlds enters the cycle as a consequence of betrayal.

Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) supplies the grammar of the scene. Johannes de silentio distinguishes the tragic hero—Agamemnon sacrificing Iphigenia—who remains within the ethical by subordinating one duty to a higher ethical duty, the state's; from Abraham, who suspends the ethical altogether for the sake of an absolute relation to God. Within the Abrahamic movement he distinguishes the knight of infinite resignation, who gives up the finite and is reconciled to its loss, from the knight of faith, who gives it up and yet believes, by virtue of the absurd, that he will receive it back. Roland at the chasm fits neither Agamemnon nor Abraham. His sacrifice serves no state, and the Tower is not God: it is a telos without a Thou. He performs the movement of resignation without the faith. Kierkegaard reserves a third category for such cases—the demonic, the single individual who stands in an absolute relation not to God but to what isolates him (*Problema* III)—and Roland at the chasm is the demonic knight, absolutely related to an object (Grade C).

The plot then supplies what Roland did not believe. In WL Jake returns, by a logic as scandalous to reason as Kierkegaard's absurd. Because Roland, in DoT, entered the mind of Jack Mort at the moment Mort was about to push Jake into traffic and prevented the push, Jake both died and did not; boy and man are split by the doubled memory until Jake is drawn bodily back through a door in a speaking ring. Isaac is returned. But the return does not absolve. Kierkegaard's Exordium imagines versions of Moriah in which Isaac, having seen the knife, loses his faith; King's Isaac comes back knowing that he was let fall, and Roland must earn a trust that Abraham never had to ask of his son.

4.2 *Omelas and the Calla*

Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagines a luminous city whose happiness depends upon the misery of a single child kept in a basement. The citizens learn the fact in adolescence; most accept it; a few walk away, toward a place the narrator cannot describe. Le Guin traced the scenario to William James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), which imagines millions kept permanently happy on condition that one lost soul at the far edge of things suffer lonely torture. Behind both stands Ivan Karamazov's

rebellion (*The Brothers Karamazov* V.4): if the eternal harmony requires the tears of a single tortured child, Ivan hastens respectfully to return his ticket.

Calla Bryn Sturgis is Omelas made agrarian and periodic. It is prosperous and pious, and once in every generation the Wolves ride out of Thunderclap to take one of each pair of twins among its children; the children come back "roont," emptied of mind, growing to giant size and dying young (WC). The town has paid the tribute for generations: this is Omelas's knowledge, domesticated as custom. Tian Jaffords's refusal is the option Le Guin's story omits. He neither acquiesces nor walks away; he calls a meeting in order to fight, and so to break the machine that makes a child's ruin the price of the city's peace.

King then answers Ivan and Le Guin by scaling their thought experiment to cosmology. The brains of the Calla's twins yield the substance that feeds the Breakers, and the Breakers are destroying the Beams. The world's end is powered by the sacrifice of children. Omelas, taken to its limit, does not merely stain the city's happiness; it consumes the universe that contains the city. The cycle's most radical ethical claim is contained in this escalation: a sacrificial economy is not a local injustice with local benefits but an entropy that eventually devours the order it was meant to secure.

4.3 *The comfortable camp*

The Breakers labor at the Devar-Toi, which its operators call the Algul Siento, "Blue Heaven." It is not a dungeon but a comfortable prison, with good food, entertainments and the ambience of a small American town, in which the Breakers perform their work as an absorbing and even pleasurable exertion. Many do not know, or do not wish to know, what their labor destroys (DT; cf. HiA). The camp is Omelas from the operators' side: contentment manufactured atop cosmic destruction. It resembles Huxley's engineered felicity in *Brave New World* (1932), and it illustrates, more exactly than any monster in the cycle, what Hannah Arendt called thoughtlessness, the quality she found in Adolf Eichmann, the SS officer who organized the deportation of Europe's Jews to the Nazi death camps: the capacity to do immense harm without thinking what one is doing (Arendt 1963). The liberation of the Breakers, the largest act of rescue in the cycle, is accomplished horizontally, in concert with the Breakers who had begun to resist from within—Ted Brautigan, Dinky Earnshaw, Sheemie Ruiz. The captives participate in their own deliverance.

4.4 *Girard: the victim revealed*

René Girard's theory of the sacred (1972; 1978; 1982) holds that mimetic desire breeds rivalry; that rivalry escalates into a crisis of undifferentiation; that communities resolve the crisis by unanimous violence against a single victim,

whose expulsion restores peace and who is afterward sacralized; that myths conceal this mechanism; and that the Gospels reveal it by proclaiming the innocence of the victim. The cycle contains three sacrificial crises, and each resolves differently.

At Tull the mimetic frenzy of Sylvia Pittston's congregation converges upon Roland, the Interloper: the unanimous crowd against one. Roland breaks the mechanism not by revelation but by counter-violence, destroying the community that would sacrifice him. At Mejis the mechanism completes itself. Susan Delgado, an insider made outsider by her love for a stranger, is accused, bound and burned alive on the Charyou Tree at the Reap festival by a crowd incited by her aunt Cordelia and the witch Rhea (WG). She is the *pharmakos* in its purest form. The festival burns effigies, and Susan's burning collapses the ritual substitute back into the collective murder that Girard says effigies commemorate: the scene dramatizes his thesis in reverse, the ritual reverting to its origin.

In the Calla the tribute is a sacrificial settlement: the town averts a war it cannot win by surrendering a portion of its young at fixed intervals. The katet's work is Girardian revelation in the key of science fiction. When the Wolves are exposed as machines and their informants as a robot and a frightened father, the sacred terror collapses into mechanism: the sacrificial order is revealed as a technology, and a technology can be fought. The battle that follows is won by the Calla's own people—the women who throw the sharpened plates of the Sisters of Oriza among them—and its victory, as in Kurosawa, belongs to the farmers.

4.5 *Compassion and the second death*

The Grail question (§1.5) has a philosophical form. Schopenhauer made compassion, *Mitleid*, the sole genuine moral incentive: the everyday mystery in which the distinction between self and other is practically abolished and another's suffering moves the will as if it were one's own (Schopenhauer 1840). Eliot's *Dayadhvam* names the same capacity. The cycle charts Roland's education in it, slowly and with relapses, from the chasm to the Calla to a road in western Maine.

At Lovell, on 19 June 1999, Jake throws himself between Stephen King and an oncoming van and is killed; Roland, who once let him fall for the sake of the Tower, now holds him as he dies (DT). The same event returns—Jake dies for the Tower—but its agent has changed. The first death was taken by a sacrificer; the second is given by the one who dies. Abraham's knife has become an Isaac who offers himself. Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) reads responsibility as the singular gift of a death that no one can die in my place, a gift that breaks the circle of exchange, in contrast to the Maussian gift that obligates a return (Mauss 1925). Jake's second death is a gift in Derrida's sense: it cannot be repaid,

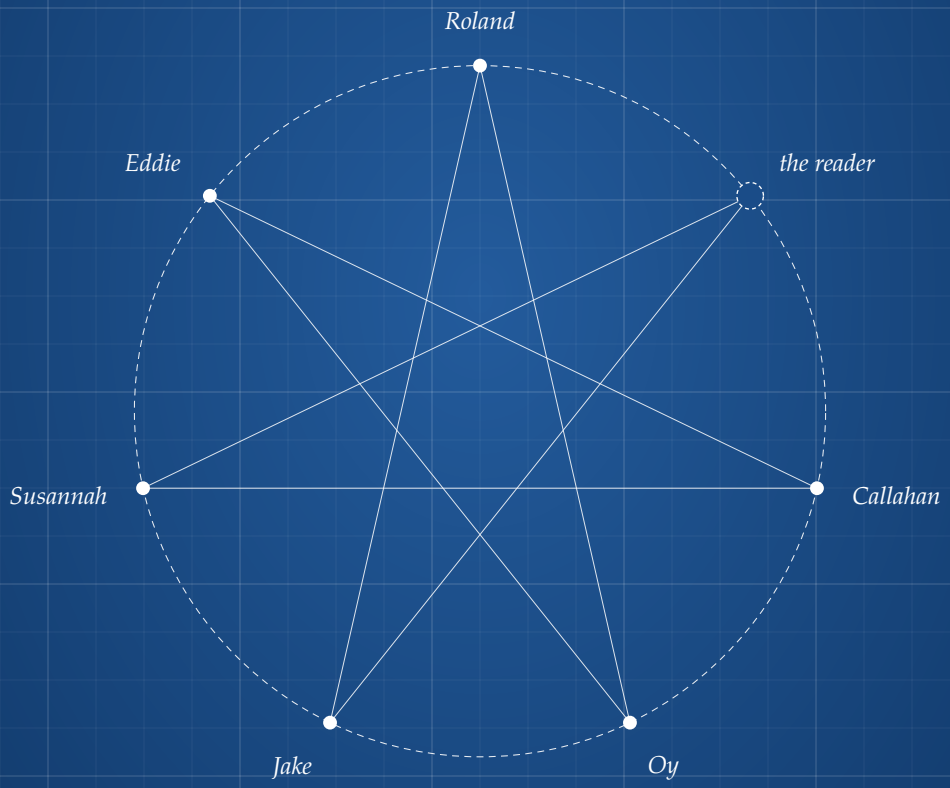
only received and remembered. Oy's death defending Roland against Mordred is the same gift, given by a creature of whom no one could have asked it.

This is the first repetition with a difference inside the cycle, and it is the template for the fifth thesis. The loop does not repeat events identically. It repeats them with the agency redistributed—from the one who spends lives toward the ones who give them, and finally, as Chapter Nine argues, toward the one who remembers.

5 *Chapter Five*

One Made from Many

The Ka-tet as an Ontology of the Host



khef: the sharing of water, and of life

The ka-tet is not a party of adventurers but an ontological claim: that to be, in the cycle, is to be convoked—drawn into a shared life through wounds, doors and names—and that the host exists in its dissolution as fully as in its union.

5.1 *The wound that requires others*

DoT opens with Roland on the beach of the Western Sea, attacked by the lobstrosities, crustacean horrors whose cries the text renders as nonsense questions. They take the first two fingers of his right hand and the great toe of his right foot, and fever follows. The maiming is a theological wound with a long ancestry (Grade B/C). The Fisher King is wounded through the thighs, a genital wound that Wolfram makes explicit (a poisoned spear strikes Anfortas in the genitals), and his sterility is his land's waste. The Irish king Nuada loses his hand in battle and is disqualified from kingship until a silver hand is made for him (*Cath Maige Tuired*). The Norse god Týr loses his hand in the jaws of the wolf Fenrir, the pledge that makes the wolf's binding possible (*Gylfaginning*). A gunslinger wounded in his shooting hand is wounded in his office; he can no longer do alone what he exists to do.

The wound is therefore the precondition of the host. The volume's title turns on a pun: to *draw* is both to draw a gun and to draw a person through a door. Maimed in the first kind of drawing, Roland must practise the second. He draws Eddie Dean and Odetta Holmes from their New Yorks, and through the third door enters the mind of Jack Mort. From this point his power passes through others.

5.2 *Eddie Dean, the Prisoner*

Eddie is a heroin addict of the 1980s, brother and dependent of the more deeply lost Henry, and the card Walter dealt as the Prisoner—Eliot's "each in his prison" (§1.6). In *On Writing* King describes his own addictions to alcohol and cocaine in the 1980s and the family intervention that ended them (OW); the Prisoner is, among other things, an authorial self-figure (Grade A for the biography, C for the identification). Eddie's gifts to the host are love, for Susannah; craft, in the whittled key that admits Jake; and above all laughter.

At the opening of WG Eddie defeats Blaine, the suicidal machine intelligence that pilots the mono, in a riddling contest, by posing jokes whose illogic the machine cannot process. The contest has an ancient lineage—Samson's riddle (Judg. 14), Oedipus and the Sphinx, Bilbo and Gollum "in the dark"—and Blaine has a modern one, running from the HAL of Kubrick and Clarke's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) to Harlan Ellison's AM in "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967), the machine that hates its makers (Grade B). Eddie's victory is Nietzschean. In *Zarathustra* III the shepherd with a black serpent lodged in his throat bites off its head, spits it out and rises transfigured, laughing as no human being has laughed; laughter is the bite that breaks the serpent of recurrence. It is also carnivalesque in Bakhtin's sense (1965): ambivalent, regenerative, uncrowning the power that would totalize. Eddie is the host's jester and

Cuthbert's heir. The second ka-tet recovers the laughter the first lost at Jericho Hill. Eddie dies at the Devar-Toi, shot in the head by Pimli Prentiss, the camp's Master, as the siege ends (DT).

5.3 *Odetta, Detta, Susannah, Mia*

Odetta Holmes is a wealthy Black heiress and civil-rights activist; Detta Walker, the personality that erupts through her, is violent, obscene and full of hatred for white people and for Odetta. The split originates in two assaults by the same white man, Jack Mort: a brick dropped upon the child's head, and, years later, a push before a subway train that costs her both legs below the knee (DoT). Du Bois's formulation is the indispensable gloss: "It is a peculiar sensation, this double-consciousness, this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others. … One ever feels his twoness,—an American, a Negro; two souls, two thoughts, two unreconciled strivings; two warring ideals in one dark body, whose dogged strength alone keeps it from being torn asunder" (Du Bois 1903). Odetta and Detta literalize the two warring ideals in one dark body, and the cycle is explicit that the tearing was done by white violence. Their integration into Susannah, achieved in a confrontation in which each personality must acknowledge the other, is King's answer to Du Bois's unreconciled strivings.

The answer is open to serious objection, which this study accepts. Detta's speech is written in a phonetic dialect, thick with racial slurs and sexual insult, that recalls minstrelsy; the text makes her violent, sexually compulsive and a shoplifter; she tries to shoot Eddie and Roland and then ties Eddie up on the beach as bait for the lobstrosities; and Roland brings Odetta into Mid-World against her will. The cycle makes Black trauma the ground on which a white hero's quest is advanced. Nnedi Okorafor-Mbachu (2004) criticized King's recurrent "magical Negro" figures; Toni Morrison's *Playing in the Dark* (1992) analyzed the Africanist presence in American literature as a screen on which white imagination projects its fears and desires; Frantz Fanon described the Black body made phobogenic and fragmented under the white gaze (Fanon 1952). Detta is, uncomfortably, such a projection: rage rendered as pathology to be integrated, the integration catalyzed by a white gunslinger's therapeutic violence and a white lover's devotion. The cycle does not refute this critique. It does, however, half-know its debt. Susannah's autonomy grows through the late volumes; in SoS she carries the narrative; and in DT she leaves Roland, refuses the final climb and walks through a door into an ending of her own. The host's most important member emancipates herself from the hero's story. Chapter Nine returns to this as the cycle's unresolved debt.

In SoS Susannah's body is occupied by Mia, a disembodied being who has taken flesh in order to bear a child—the "chap" who will be Mordred. Mia's maternity is the only unambiguous love in the Crimson King's camp, and she is

also a figure of surrogacy, of a Black woman's body colonized for another's purposes; after the birth in Fedic, Mordred's first act is to devour her. The doubling of Susannah and Mia repeats the doubling of Odetta and Detta at the level of reproduction. Susannah's final ending, the drawn door into a snowbound Central Park where Eddie and Jake await her, is Bunyan's second part (§1.8): the pilgrimage of the host rather than of the hero.

5.4 *Jake Chambers: the child as reader*

Jake is the neglected son of a Manhattan television executive, raised largely by a housekeeper. He resembles Jung's *puer aeternus*, the eternal youth who belongs to the spirit and resists incarnation (von Franz 1970), but King inverts the archetype. Jake is the one member of the ka-tet who matures in the course of the cycle, from abandoned boy to a gunslinger in spirit while remaining a child in body. His Final Essay (§0.4) is at once a satire of overinterpretation and a prophecy: an adolescent's intuition of the other world expressed as nonsense that proves literally true. The child is the cycle's hermeneutic figure, the one who reads the signs of a world before he can understand them. The reader of the cycle stands where Jake stood when he wrote the essay.

5.5 *Oy*

Oy, the billy-bumbler, a small badger-like creature with a few words of speech, attaches himself to Jake in WL and remains with the ka-tet to the end, dying to protect Roland from Mordred (DT). The faithful animal is ancient: Argos, Odysseus's dog, recognizes his master after twenty years and dies (*Od.* XVII). Derrida's *The Animal That Therefore I Am* (2006) begins from the philosopher's shame before the gaze of his cat and argues that the tradition's single line between "the human" and "the animal" is itself a violence. Agamben's *The Open* (2002) names the "anthropological machine" that produces the human by excluding the animal within it. Oy is the ka-tet's refutation of that machine: membership of the host is not bounded by species. His death is the last dismantling of the tet before the summit. After Oy, Roland is alone.

5.6 *Callahan*

Father Donald Callahan enters the cycle from *'Salem's Lot*, where his faith fails before the vampire Barlow, who breaks his cross and forces him to drink his blood (SL). He wanders the "highways in hiding," other versions of America, until a door brings him to the Calla, where he becomes the Pere (WC). There he is shown a novel called *'Salem's Lot* by one Stephen King and discovers himself as a character: the cycle's first case of ontological vertigo (Chapter Seven).

He dies in the Dixie Pig in New York. Having held the vampires and Low Men off with the scrimshaw turtle and a faith restored as practice, so that Jake and Oy can escape, he turns his gun on himself rather than be taken by the Crimson King's servants (DT). A priest's suicide, which Catholic teaching treats as gravely wrong, is presented by the cycle as an act of faith and sacrifice; the tension belongs to Chapter Four's distinction between a death taken and a death given. Callahan's arc runs from faith as a possession, which can be broken like a cross, to faith as an act, which cannot.

5.7 *An ontology of the host*

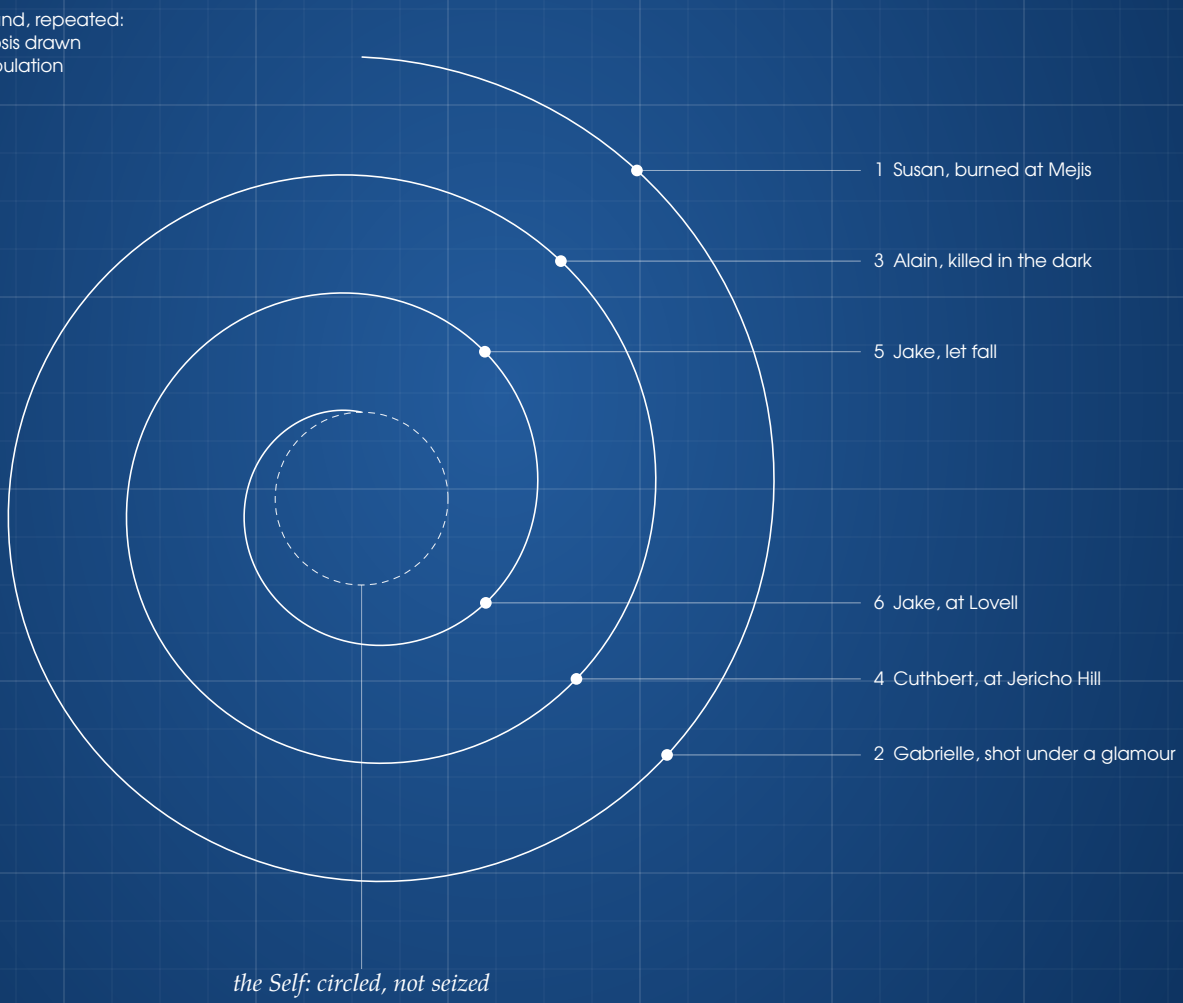
The cycle defines the ka-tet as "one made from many" and binds it by *khef*, a High Speech word glossed as the sharing of water and, more deeply, of life and thought; its members come to share dreams and a telepathic "touch." The philosophical analogues are exact (Grade C). For Heidegger, being-with (*Mitsein*) is an existential structure of Dasein, which is always already with others, so that solitude is only a deficient mode of being-with (Heidegger 1927, §26). For Jean-Luc Nancy, community is not a work—not the fusion of individuals into a substantial whole, as in the operative communities of nation, race and party—but the sharing (*partage*) of finitude, the exposure of singular beings to one another; the community is *désœuvrée*, inoperative, and to be is to be singular plural (Nancy 1986; 1996). The ka-tet is inoperative in Nancy's sense. It produces no work that outlasts it; it is dissolved by deaths; its essence is exposure. Dan Simmons posited empathy as a fundamental physical force, the Void Which Binds (Simmons 1989–90); *khef* is its Mid-World counterpart.

Against the host stands the tower as the architecture of solitude in European letters: Montaigne's library tower, where he withdrew to write the *Essais*; Hölderlin's tower in Tübingen, where he lived for thirty-six years in madness; Yeats's Thoor Ballylee and the volume he named *The Tower* (1928); Jung's Bollingen (Chapter Six). Roland reaches the Tower alone, having lost or released every member of his ka-tet, and so he arrives as a tower rather than as a host. Yeats, in that same volume, wrote the epitaph of such an arrival: "An aged man is but a paltry thing, / A tattered coat upon a stick, unless / Soul clap its hands and sing, and louder sing / For every tatter in its mortal dress" ("Sailing to Byzantium"). The loop, as Chapter Nine argues, is the Tower's answer to that solitude.

6 *Chapter Six*

The Wound That Speaks

Trauma, Repetition, Individuation



Roland's biography is a textbook case of what Freud called the fate neurosis, and the cycle's concept of ka *is, in one register, the compulsion to repeat externalized as cosmology. Its resolution is not cure but a Jungian circumambulation, in which the center is circled rather than seized.*

6.1 *Mejis as confession*

WG is structurally a confession. Roland tells the story of his fourteenth year to the ka-tet in a single night, on a highway through a plague-emptied Kansas. After his premature trial he is sent with Cuthbert and Alain to the Outer Arc barony of Mejis. There he loves Susan Delgado, who has been promised as a concubine to the town's mayor, Hart Thorin; he uncovers Farson's conspiracy and the hired guns who serve it; and he falls under the spell of Maerlyn's Grapefruit, a pink seeing-stone from the wizard's rainbow of glasses. Susan is burned while Roland, entranced by the glass, is elsewhere. He returns to Gilead and kills his mother. The telling itself is the therapeutic act Shoshana Felman and Dori Laub describe in *Testimony* (1992): trauma becomes narratable only in the presence of a listener able to bear witness. The ka-tet is Roland's first audience, and so the first condition of his recovery.

6.2 *Freud: the daemonic compulsion*

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) begins from phenomena that contradict the pleasure principle: the dreams of traumatic neurotics, which return to the catastrophe; a child's game of throwing away and retrieving a spool, *fort* and *da*; and the "fate neurosis," in which a life repeats the same catastrophe as if pursued by a daemonic power—the benefactor abandoned by each protégé in turn, the man whose every friendship ends in betrayal, the lover whose affairs pass through the same phases to the same end. Freud's culminating example is Tasso's *Gerusalemme liberata* (1581). Tancred unknowingly kills his beloved Clorinda, who fights in an enemy knight's armour; later, in an enchanted forest, he slashes a tree, blood streams from the cut, and the voice of Clorinda, whose soul is imprisoned there, complains that he has wounded his beloved once again. Cathy Caruth made the scene the paradigm of modern trauma theory: the voice that cries out from the wound, bearing witness to a truth the subject could not know when the event occurred (Caruth 1996).

Roland is Tancred. He wounds the beloved again and again: Susan, lost through his absence; Gabrielle, killed by his hand under a glamour; Alain, killed in the dark by the friendly fire of Roland and Cuthbert; Cuthbert, dead at Jericho Hill; Jake, let fall; Jake again, at Lovell. What the characters call *ka* is, in one register, exactly Freud's daemonic fate—the compulsion to repeat externalized as cosmology. The loop at the Tower raises the fate neurosis to a cosmic principle. Yet Freud's own *fort*/*da* suggests that repetition is also an attempt at mastery: the child who throws the spool away and draws it back converts passive suffering into active play. The Tower casts Roland away and draws him back. It is the *fort*/*da* of the cosmos, and the question the cycle leaves open is whether the child playing it will learn, at last, to bear the absence.

6.3 *Lacan: the drive's circuit and the letter that arrives*

In *Seminar XI* (1964) Lacan distinguishes two forms of repetition, borrowing Aristotle's terms from the *Physics*: *automaton*, the insistence of the signifying chain, and *tuché*, the encounter with the real that occurs "as if by chance" beyond it. The drive, he argues, never attains its object; its aim—the path it travels—is satisfied in circling the object, the *objet petit a*, which is not the object of desire but its cause, a void about which the drive loops. The Tower is Roland's *objet a*: not a thing he wants but the cause of his wanting, a void that organizes every movement of his life. Its inaccessibility maintains his desire; its attainment would abolish the subject who desires. Browning's fourth stanza is Lacanian before the letter: the heart leaps at failure because failure preserves desire. The loop is the drive's circuit made visible.

Lacan's seminar on Poe's "Purloined Letter" (1956) ends with the claim that a letter always arrives at its destination; Derrida replied that a letter can always fail to arrive, and that the possibility of non-arrival haunts every destination (Derrida 1980). WTK contains a letter. At the close of that interpolated volume the young Roland, shortly after the matricide, receives a letter his mother wrote before her death and left at a retreat she had visited, in which Gabrielle tells him she knows what is coming and forgives him in advance (WTK). The letter arrives. But the forgiveness it carries does not prevent anything that follows—the long quest, the summit, the loop. The letter reaches its addressee without reaching the one who needs it, for the Roland who climbs the Tower has not forgiven himself. The cycle stages Lacan and Derrida at once: forgiveness delivered and not yet claimed. Caruth's "unclaimed experience" has an obverse, and it is unclaimed grace.

6.4 *Jung: shadow, anima, Self*

Jung's structural psychology, in its popular currency (Grade B), supplies the cycle's character-system. The first sentence is itself a formula of the first stage of individuation: the ego pursues its dark double across the desert. Walter is Roland's shadow, the man in black whom the gunslinger hunts through the whole cycle and never integrates, and Walter's end—eaten by Mordred (DT)—shows the shadow consumed by its own offspring rather than assimilated. Le Guin's Ged, by contrast, names his shadow with his own name and becomes whole (Chapter Eight). The anima returns under a single name, Susan and then Susannah, as though the psyche insisted on repeating its feminine figure until it could be kept; Susannah is kept, but not by Roland. The Self, the center and totality of the psyche represented in mandalas and quaternities, is the Tower: a structure at the crossing of six Beams is a mandala in plan.

Jung built a tower of his own. Bollingen, on the upper lake of Zurich, was

begun in 1923, shortly after his mother's death, extended in 1927, 1931 and 1935, and given an upper storey in 1955, after his wife's death; in *Memories, Dreams, Reflections* he describes it, in effect, as a confession of faith in stone, each addition answering to a stage in the growth of his psyche (Jung 1962). Roland's Tower, whose rooms hold the relics of his life floor by floor, is Bollingen read from the inside: a structure accreted from a life.

Jung's most important claim for this study concerns form. In the same memoir he reports his discovery that the psyche's development is not linear: there is only a circumambulation of the self, the mandala is the center, and all paths lead toward it by circling (Jung 1962, paraphrased). Individuation does not reach the Self; it circles it. On Jung's account the loop is not the failure of individuation but its proper figure, and the *uroboros*, the serpent that eats its tail, which Jung found everywhere in the alchemical literature (1944), is the emblem of an opus that ends in its beginning.

6.5 *Alchemy: the Black, the White and the Red*

The alchemical opus proceeded through *nigredo*, a blackening or putrefaction; *albedo*, a whitening; and *rubedo*, a reddening, culminating in the *coniunctio* of the Red King and the White Queen and the birth of the *filius philosophorum*, the philosophical child (Jung 1944; 1946; 1955–56). The cycle's color-system is alchemical (Grade C): the Dark Tower is the *nigredo*; "the White" is the cycle's own name for the force of good that the Line of Eld serves; the Crimson King is a *rubedo* gone wrong. The *Rosarium Philosophorum* (1550), whose woodcuts Jung analyzed in *The Psychology of the Transference* (1946), stages the *coniunctio* of the Red and the White in a rose garden: King's Rose and King's Red King, in one emblem book.

Mordred is the monstrous *filius*. He is the child of the White, Roland, and the Red, the Crimson King, gestated in the vessel of Susannah and Mia—a *coniunctio* achieved without the feminine as partner, the feminine reduced to a vessel, and so producing not the stone but a spider, which devours the vessel at birth. The alchemical reading explains why the double paternity must exist: Mordred is the failed opus of a hero who has tried to make the Red and the White coexist in himself, pursuing the White's ends by the Red's means.

The third Rosicrucian text, *The Chymical Wedding of Christian Rosenkreutz* (1616), attributed to Johann Valentin Andreae, supplies the loop's most precise alchemical analogue. Over seven days Christian ascends the Tower of Olympus floor by floor, assisting at the alchemical resurrection of a royal couple. Earlier, straying into the castle's vaults, he has looked upon Venus lying naked and asleep, and the transgression entails that he must take the place of the castle's aged porter, who had committed the same fault and been bound to keep the gate until another repeated it. The text breaks off, lacunary, with the narrator's

return home. The porter's condition is a guilt-loop: whoever transgresses at the heart of the mystery becomes the keeper of its threshold, until another repeats the transgression. Roland's loop has this shape. Having looked upon what he should not—the summit—he is returned to the gate, to keep the threshold by beginning again.

6.6 *Self-forgiveness and the condition of repetition*

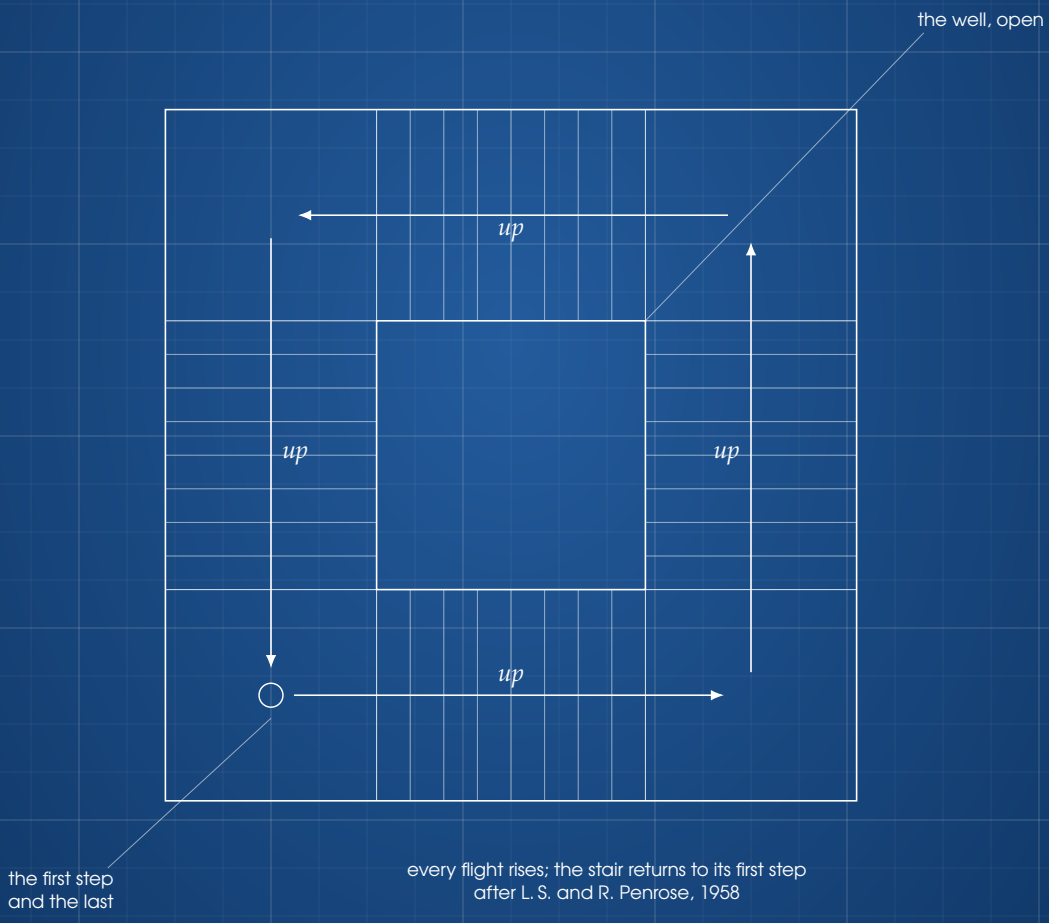
In Yeats's "A Dialogue of Self and Soul" the Self declares itself content to live the whole of its life again, every folly and humiliation, and in casting out remorse finds itself blessed (paraphrased). That is the psychological condition of what Chapter Nine calls Olifantine Repetition: a loop can be affirmed rather than suffered only when remorse is cast out and forgiveness received. Gabrielle's letter is the external form of that forgiveness, and the Horn of Eld will be its object-form. At the summit Roland reviews his life in rooms, which is recollection; he is returned carrying the Horn, which is the possibility of repetition. Kierkegaard's distinction—recollection repeats backward, genuine repetition is recollected forward—names the difference (Chapter Nine). The trauma that repeats as fate may, once witnessed and forgiven, repeat as freedom.

7

Chapter Seven

The Author at Lovell

Metalepsis, Strange Loops and the Kenosis of the Writer



every flight rises; the stair returns to its first step
after L. S. and R. Penrose, 1958

King's entry into his own fiction is not an apotheosis of the author but a kenosis. The creator appears as a frightened servant whom his creatures must save, and his name is distributed across father, adversary and victim, so that even at the level of authorship the center of the cycle is kept empty.

7.1 The writer in the text

In SoS Roland and Eddie cross into the Maine of 1977 and visit the young Stephen King at his home in Bridgton: a nervous, drinking writer who has set aside the gunslinger's story because it frightens him. Roland hypnotizes him, as he once hypnotized Susan Delgado, with a cartridge walked across his knuckles, and instructs him to resume the story whenever he hears the song of the Beam. The volume closes with pages from the writer's fictional journal and a fictional obituary reporting King's death in June 1999 (SoS). In DT the prophecy is averted. On 19 June 1999, on a road in Lovell, Maine, Jake throws King clear of a van driven—as in historical fact—by a man named Bryan Smith, and is killed in his place (DT).

Genette named this transgression *metalepsis*: any intrusion of the world in which one tells into the world of which one tells, or the reverse, across the frontier that narrative normally keeps sacred (Genette 1972). Brian McHale made such frame-breaking the signature of postmodern fiction, whose dominant is ontological rather than epistemological: its question is not *how can I know this world?* but *which world is this, and what happens when worlds collide?* (McHale 1987; cf. Waugh 1984; Hutcheon 1980). King's metalepsis is unusual in its direction and valence. His characters cross into the author's world not to protest their creation but to preserve their creator. It is redemptive metalepsis.

7.2 Precedents and inversions

The history of the author's appearance among his creatures is a history of power relations, and each precedent defines one (Grade C). In Unamuno's *Niebla* (1914) Augusto Pérez visits his author in Salamanca to discuss his planned suicide; the author informs him that he is a fiction and will die by authorial decree; Augusto retorts that the author, too, may be only a figure in God's dream—and is killed off. In Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921) abandoned characters demand to be performed. In Flann O'Brien's *At Swim-Two-Birds* (1939) characters drug their author, Dermot Trellis, to escape his control while he sleeps. In Vonnegut's *Breakfast of Champions* (1973) the author enters his novel, frees his character Kilgore Trout, and hears Trout beg to be made young. In Fowles's *The French Lieutenant's Woman* (1969) the author sits in a railway compartment observing his hero, later turns back his watch to offer an alternative ending, and argues that a novelist who wishes his characters to live must grant them freedom, as a God who withdraws grants freedom to creatures (paraphrased). In Grant Morrison's *Animal Man* #26 (1990) Buddy Baker meets his writer and learns that his family's death was a narrative device. In Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981) the author splits into the narrator "Phil" and Horselover Fat, a Greek-German translation of his own name.

Protest, rebellion, emancipation, abdication, exposure, dissociation: each precedent stages the author's power and the creature's response to it. King's contribution is the rescue. His creatures die for their author, and the relation of creation is not dissolved but inverted into mutual dependence: the author's survival sustains the Beam, and the Beam sustains the author's world.

7.3 *Borges, Carroll and the dreamed dreamer*

Borges supplies the cycle's metaphysical figures (Grade C). In "The Circular Ruins" (1940) a man dreams a son into reality and then discovers, walking unburned through fire, that he too is another's dream. King in SoS is the dreamed dreamer: the author of Roland's world is shown to be moved in his turn by the Beam, the servant of a story he did not invent. "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines an invented world gradually replacing the real; "The Aleph" (1945), a point in space that contains all points—the Tower as the point of all wheres and whens; "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), a labyrinth in time in which all outcomes occur; "The Library of Babel" (1941), the total library. And Borges's essays on circular time distinguish three doctrines of return: Plato's great year, Nietzsche's eternal return of the same, and a subtler third, of cycles similar but not identical (Borges 1936; 1953)—the doctrine Chapter Nine assigns to the Tower.

Carroll supplies the terror. In *Through the Looking-Glass* Alice finds the Red King asleep, and Tweedledee tells her he is dreaming about her: "And if he left off dreaming about you, where do you suppose you'd be?" "Where I am now, of course," said Alice. "Not you!" Tweedledee retorted contemptuously. "You'd be nowhere. Why, you're only a sort of thing in his dream!" Tweedledum adds that if the King woke she would go out—"bang!—just like a candle!" This is precisely the peril of SoS and DT: if the writer stops, by abandoning the story or by dying, the worlds go out. The onomastics confirm the lineage. Carroll's Red King, whose dream sustains Alice, returns in King as two figures: the Crimson King, who would end all worlds, and Stephen King, whose dreaming sustains them.

7.4 *The distributed name*

The author's name is distributed across the cycle in three places. It appears as *Steven*, the father whose face the gunslinger must not forget; as *King*, the Crimson King, whose project—the ending of every world—is identical in effect with the author's abandonment of his tale, and whose agents therefore seek the writer's death; and as *Stephen King*, the vulnerable man on the road at Lovell. The author is figured as origin, as threat and as creature: a trinity of authorship with no single seat. He is no more at the center of his cycle than a

god is at the top of the Tower; his name is spread along the Beam. King's self-portrait is unflattering—frightened, drinking, evasive—and the cycle's metaphysics makes the author a Beam rather than the Tower: a conduit and a buttress, not an occupant of the center.

7.5 *Fossil, magnet and the kenosis of the author*

In *On Writing* King describes stories as found things, like fossils: the writer's task is to excavate each one as intact as possible, with the most delicate tools available (OW, paraphrased). The image descends from Plato's *Ion*, in which the Muse is a magnet and poet, rhapsode and audience are iron rings suspended from one another by the force that passes through them: "For the poet is a light and winged and holy thing, and there is no invention in him until he has been inspired and is out of his senses" (534b, trans. Jowett). The cycle literalizes the *Ion*. The writer is a ring through which the Beam's force passes, and the voice of Gan reaches the reader through him.

Barthes announced the death of the author (1967) and Foucault analyzed the author-function (1969). King does something else: he does not kill the author; he empties him. Bloom's third revisionary ratio, *kenosis*, names a humbling self-emptying by which the later poet also empties his precursor (Bloom 1973). In the cycle the ratio becomes theological: the author portrays himself in the form of a servant (Phil. 2:7). It is also Lurianic. The author withdraws his omnipotence to leave space for his creatures' freedom—an authorial *tzimtzum*—and the Coda's offer of two endings is that withdrawal made explicit. The structure is the Tower's: power manifested as withdrawal.

7.6 *Strange loops and the Penrose stair*

Douglas Hofstadter defines a strange loop as the phenomenon whereby, moving upward or downward through the levels of a hierarchical system, one finds oneself unexpectedly back where one started (Hofstadter 1979; 2007). Escher's *Drawing Hands* (1948), in which each hand draws the other, is the cycle's author drawing characters who save the author. Escher's *Ascending and Descending* (1960), built on the impossible staircase published by L. S. and Roger Penrose (1958), shows monks who climb forever and never rise. The Tower's stair is a Penrose stair: every ascent returns to the ground, which is the desert.

Gödel's first incompleteness theorem (1931) shows that any consistent formal system rich enough to express arithmetic contains true sentences it cannot prove, and it constructs, by self-reference, a sentence that says of itself that it is unprovable. The analogy is structural, not technical, but it is exact. The cycle cannot contain its own ending; the summit is its undecidable sentence; and the

return to the first sentence is the self-reference by which the system refers to itself without closing.

7.7 *The eraser and the whimper*

Patrick Danville enters from *Insomnia*, where the Purpose protects him as a child because he will one day save the life of a man of great importance (Ins). In DT he is a mute artist whose drawings become real. Before the Tower he draws the Crimson King on his balcony and then erases him, leaving only the eyes (DT). The cycle's antagonist is undone by erasure. Heidegger wrote *Being* crossed through, to mark a word both necessary and inadequate (Heidegger 1955); Derrida generalized the practice as writing *sous rature*, under erasure, in which the erased remains legible and the trace persists (Derrida 1967). The Crimson King's eyes remain: evil erased, not annihilated.

His name deepens the scene. Los' the Red recalls Blake's Los, the Eternal Prophet and smith of the imagination, who declares: "I must Create a System, or be enslav'd by another Mans / I will not Reason & Compare: my business is to Create" (*Jerusalem*, pl. 10). King's Los is Blake's Los inverted, imagination turned wholly to destruction, and he is defeated by another artist. Only art can unmake the usurper of art.

The anticlimax is deliberate. Conrad's Kurtz, at the Inner Station, is "hollow at the core" (*Heart of Darkness*), a usurper who has filled the center with himself and been filled in turn by the wilderness. Eliot's "The Hollow Men" (1925), which takes its epigraph from Conrad—"Mistah Kurtz—he dead"—ends: "This is the way the world ends / Not with a bang but a whimper." The Crimson King goes out with a whimper, erased by a young man with a pencil, because the cycle refuses to make the usurper's defeat a spectacular act of power: spectacular seizure of the center is the usurper's own genre. Two hollownesses must therefore be distinguished. The usurper's is a center hollowed by appetite; the hub's and the horn's is an emptiness that gives use. The cycle's metaphysics depends upon the difference.

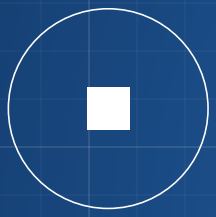
7.8 *The Coda as Limit*

The Coda offers two endings and invites the reader to stop at the first. The author attempts to restrain the reader from climbing to the top, and so plays toward the reader the part the Tower plays toward Roland: that of a Limit, the Valentinian *Horos* that Chapter Nine describes. The last climber of the Tower is the reader, and the last restraint is the author's plea. The metafiction's final act is not the author's entrance into his book but his attempt to stop the reader from completing it.

8 *Chapter Eight*

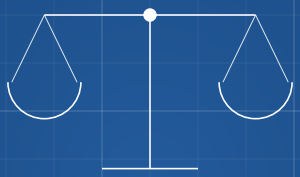
Other Towers

The Cycle among Speculative and Philosophical Fictions



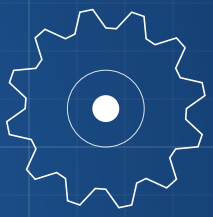
the throne

Zelazny, Herbert



the balance

Moorcock



the machine

Asimov, Ellison, the Old Ones



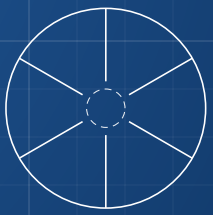
the completion

Clarke



the absent god

Stapledon



the empty hub

The Dark Tower

Set among the speculative cosmologies of its century, the cycle's distinctiveness becomes measurable. Where other fictions place at their center a throne, a balance, a machine, a list or an absent god, King places an emptiness that must be protected from every occupant, the hero included. This chapter builds that typology (§8.12).

8.1 *Tolkien: the Ring and the Tower*

The Lord of the Rings is the great quest of renunciation: its object is to be destroyed, not won (Grade A). At the Crack of Doom Frodo fails—he claims the Ring—and is saved by Gollum, whose survival to that moment was secured by the pity of Bilbo and Frodo. Tolkien's eucatastrophe, the sudden joyous turn he theorized in "On Fairy-Stories" (1947), is achieved through mercy shown to the shadow. The Ring and the Tower are antithetical centers: the Ring must be unmade because it is the usurper's condensed will; the Tower must be preserved because it is the empty hub. Yet they teach one structural lesson. The quester who reaches the center wants it; Frodo's claim at Sammath Naur is Roland's climb. Tolkien's rescue comes from outside, through Gollum's fall; King's comes from the center itself, through the Tower's return.

Michael Moorcock's "Epic Pooh" (1978) attacked Tolkien's consolatory conservatism—the comforts of the Shire, the restoration of the king. King's cycle stands nearer to Moorcock's critique than to Tolkien's consolation. Gilead is not restored, no rightful king returns to his throne, and the one consolatory ending the cycle offers, Susannah's, is offered by the Coda and then declined as untrue.

8.2 *Moorcock: the Balance*

Moorcock's Eternal Champion—Elric, Corum, Hawkmoon, Erekosë—is a single hero reincarnated across worlds and compelled to serve the Cosmic Balance between Law and Chaos. Elric's soul-drinking sword Stormbringer kills his beloved Cymoril and, at last, his friends (*Stormbringer*, 1965); Roland's guns, and the quest they serve, consume his companions as Stormbringer consumes Elric's. The Champion's recurrence is a curse the multiverse lays upon him, relieved only in Tanelorn, the city where champions rest. The difference is architectural. Moorcock's center is a balance, an equilibrium in which neither principle may prevail. King's is an emptiness, a hollow that neither the White nor the Red may fill. The White serves the Beam; it does not seek the center.

8.3 *Zelazny: the Pattern and the throne*

Zelazny's Amber sequence (1970–1991) makes Amber the one true world, of which all others are Shadows, with the Pattern inscribed at its heart and the Courts of Chaos arrayed against it. Brand's assault damages the Pattern, and Oberon repairs it at the cost of his life while Corwin inscribes a new one. Amber answers to the Keystone World, the Pattern's damage to the Breakers' work, its repair to *tikkun*. But Zelazny's center is a throne. The novels are a war of succession among royal siblings, and the metaphysics serves a dynastic plot.

King's center has no throne: the Crimson King is locked outside it, the Line of Eld ends in Roland, and the Tower is anti-dynastic.

8.4 *Eddison, Joyce, Delany: books that end at their beginning*

In Eddison's *The Worm Ouroboros* (1922) the lords of Demonland, having destroyed Witchland, grieve that no worthy enemy remains; the gods grant their prayer, the world is restored to its state at the story's beginning, and the book closes with the arrival of an embassy from Witchland, as it began. Recurrence is a gift to warriors who desire eternal war. Roland's loop shares the form, but the Horn subverts Eddison's aristocratic desire: Eddison's heroes want their enemies back, whereas the Horn calls not the enemy but the host.

Joyce's *Finnegans Wake* (1939), built upon Vico's cycles, ends mid-clause in a sentence completed by its first word, "riverrun." Joyce's loop is linguistic and familial, the fall of HCE and the river of ALP returning to its source; King's is ethical. Delany's *Dhalgren* (1975) joins its closing fragment to its opening one, and its protagonist, the Kid, cannot remember his own name as he wanders the burning city of Bellona. Delany's Kid and King's Roland are the two great amnesiacs of the looped novel. Neither remembers the previous circuit; only the reader does.

8.5 *Self-generating loops and the memory of ruins: Heinlein, Wolfe, Miller, Hoban*

Heinlein's "By His Bootstraps" (1941) and " '—All You Zombies—' " (1959) construct causal loops in which a person becomes his own predecessor; in the latter, through time travel and a change of sex, the protagonist is his own mother and father. Mordred's double paternity is the monstrous version: not a self that generates itself, but a hero and his adversary co-generating a third. Gene Wolfe's *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83) and *The Urth of the New Sun* (1987) give their narrator, Severian, a perfect memory and build their metaphysics on temporal loops, in which beings of the far future shape the past so as to bring about their own origin. Roland is Severian's opposite, a hero without memory of his loops; Wolfe's loop is underwritten by a Catholic grace, King's by a horn.

Walter M. Miller's *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) traces two millennia in which civilization is destroyed, rebuilt and destroyed again by nuclear war, while the monks of the Albertian Order of Leibowitz preserve fragments of the old learning through the dark age. The monastery is a katechontic institution of memory, and King's Tet Corporation is a secular order of Leibowitz, a fellowship that keeps one fragment—the Rose—through the long night. Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980) sets its story in a post-nuclear Kent whose English has decayed and whose sacred myth recounts, in ruined words, the

splitting of the atom. Mid-World's High Speech and relics are Riddley's world transposed: in both, catastrophe leaves a civilization reading its past through broken language.

8.6 *Endings by completion: Asimov, Clarke, Ellison, Stapledon*

In Asimov's "The Last Question" (1956), humanity's successor intelligence, having at last learned after the heat-death of the universe how to reverse entropy, pronounces the words of Genesis: "Let there be light." The machine becomes God. King's Old Ones sought the same apotheosis of the machine and failed; the cycle denies that the center can be maintained by machines. In Clarke's "The Nine Billion Names of God" (1953), Tibetan monks employ a computer to complete their list of the names of God, and when the list is complete the universe's purpose is fulfilled and the stars begin to go out. Completion is the end. The Crimson King is the cosmos's Clarkean monk, and Roland's summit is a completion forestalled.

Ellison's AM (1967) is the machine god whose hatred keeps its last humans alive in torment—the type of Blaine. Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937) carries its narrator's spirit to the maker of all cosmoi and discovers a creator who contemplates his creatures' agony with a detached, aesthetic ecstasy; the vision is at once terrible and reverent. Stapledon's is the absent god. King's Tower is not aloof but withdrawn: its absence is not indifference but the condition of other beings' existence.

8.7 *Le Guin: shadow, hole, wheel*

Le Guin supplies three figures. In *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968) the young Ged, out of pride, looses a shadow that hunts him; he turns and hunts it to the world's edge, names it with his own name and becomes whole. King's first sentence could open Ged's story, but Roland never names his shadow as himself, and Walter is eaten by Mordred rather than integrated (§6.4). In *The Farthest Shore* (1972) the sorcerer Cob, craving immortality, opens a breach between life and death through which the world's magic drains away, and Ged closes it at the cost of all his power. Cob's breach is the Breakers' work; Ged's sacrifice is the Tower's economy, in which the world is repaired by one who gives power up.

The Lathe of Heaven (1971), whose title descends from an English rendering of Zhuangzi's *tianjun*, the heavenly potter's wheel, imagines George Orr, whose dreams reshape reality, and the psychiatrist Haber, who seeks to use those dreams to perfect the world. Haber is the utopian usurper of the dreamer's power, as the Crimson King is the usurper of the Breakers'. And Le Guin's own rendering of the *Daodejing* (1997) makes explicit the Laozian thread in speculative fiction to which King's empty hub is the unwitting counterpart.

8.8 *Herbert: the prescient throne*

In Herbert's *Dune* (1965) Paul Atreides's prescience shows him the holy war he cannot prevent, and the messiah becomes a trap. In *God Emperor of Dune* (1981) Leto II occupies the center for three and a half millennia as a tyrant, in order to set humanity on the Golden Path that will free it from prescient tyranny forever. Herbert gives the purest case of a center occupied for salvation's sake: centripetal usurpation rendered benevolent. King refuses the God Emperor. No one may sit at the summit, not even to save the world, and the ka-tet saves the world precisely by leaving the summit empty.

8.9 *McCarthy, Simmons, Gaiman, Moore, Vonnegut*

McCarthy's Judge Holden in *Blood Meridian* (1985)—vast, hairless, erudite, dancing, a scalp-hunter who, the novel implies, kills the Apache boy he has befriended, and who proclaims war the ultimate trade and himself undying—is Walter's closest literary kinsman, the demonic trickster of the American West. McCarthy's *The Road* (2006) gives a father and son "carrying the fire" across a burned world: the fire is the horizontal transmission of the human, McCarthy's Horn. Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* (1989) frames its pilgrims' tales on the road to the Time Tombs as a Canterbury, of which WG is Roland's tale, and its sequel names empathy the Void Which Binds. Gaiman's *The Sandman* (1989–96) ends with Dream, unable to change, choosing his own death, so that a changed Dream may replace him; Roland likewise cannot change except by being returned. Moore and Gibbons's *Watchmen* (1986–87) ends with a being who perceives all time at once telling his interlocutor that nothing ever ends. Vonnegut's Tralfamadorians in *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) see every moment simultaneously and meet death with a shrug: so it goes. *Ka* resembles Tralfamadorian time, but the Horn refutes it: something can be carried into the moment that was not there before.

8.10 *Chiang and the loop of care*

In Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) the linguist Louise Banks, having learned the heptapods' language, perceives her life all at once, her daughter's early death included, and chooses it anyway, narrating to her daughter in a tense that knows the ending. Knowledge of the end does not abolish the choice to live toward it: this is *amor fati* with love. Harold Ramis's *Groundhog Day* (1993) traps a man in a repeating day that releases him only when he spends it in service to the town, saving whom he can and learning to care. The loop ends not by the hero's ascent but by his convocation into a community. It is the closest popular

analogue to Olifantine Repetition: the repetition is purgatorial, the difference is care, and the release comes horizontally.

8.11 The wheel and emptiness

The Buddhist parallel is structural (Grade C). The *bhavacakra* places the three poisons at its hub (§2.7), and Nāgārjuna's most radical claim is that there is not the slightest difference between *saṃsāra* and *nirvāṇa*: the limit of the one is the limit of the other (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 25.19–20). Liberation is not an escape from the wheel to another place but the wheel's transformation by the realization of emptiness. Read in this light, the Tower's return is not a failure of transcendence. It discloses that the summit and the desert are one place, seen with or without the Horn.

8.12 A typology of centers

The comparisons yield six types of fictional center. The last is King's.

Type of center	*Exemplary fictions*	*What occupies the center*	*How the story resolves*
Throne	Zelazny's Amber; Herbert's *God Emperor of Dune*	A ruler or royal line	Succession, or benevolent tyranny
Balance	Moorcock's Eternal Champion sequence	An equilibrium of Law and Chaos	Endless service to the equilibrium
Machine	Asimov's "The Last Question"; Ellison's AM; King's Old Ones	A computing intelligence	Apotheosis or tyranny of the machine
Completion	Clarke's "The Nine Billion Names of God"	A finite list or task	The world ends when the task is done
Absent god	Stapledon's *Star Maker*	A creator who contemplates without love	Reverent disillusion
Empty hub	*The Dark Tower* (anticipated by Laozi, Le Guin, Tolkien's renunciation)	Nothing: a kept emptiness	Return, and the convocation of a host

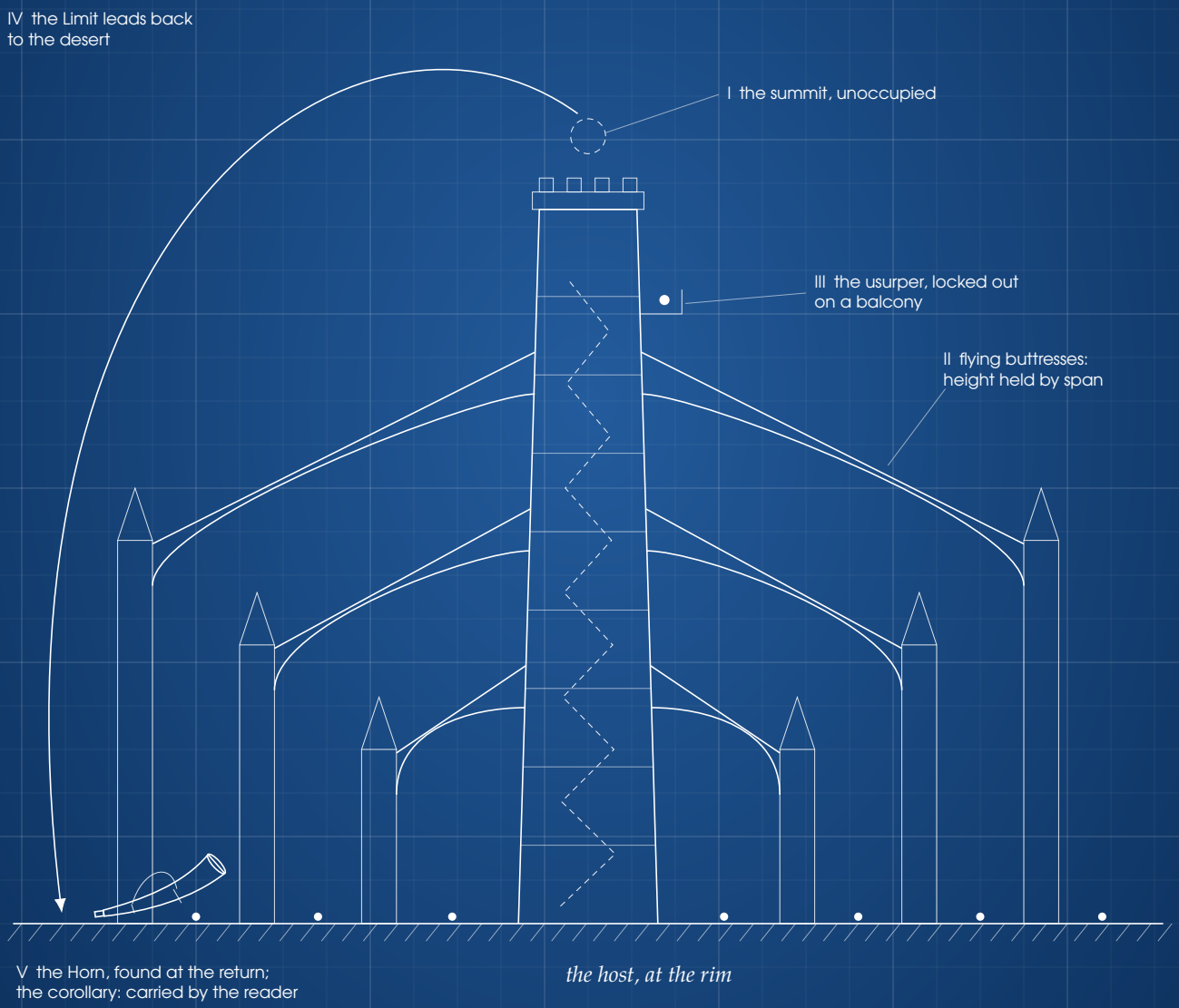
Only the last type makes the protection of the center's emptiness the work of the story, and only the last requires that the hero himself be refused. That refusal is the subject of the next chapter.

9

Chapter Nine

The Hub and the Host

Five Theses and a Corollary



The findings of the preceding chapters can now be stated as five theses and a corollary. Each rests on textual evidence and each resolves one of the cruxes named in the Introduction; together they reclassify the cycle as a katechontic romance.

9.1 *Thesis I — Kenotic Axiality*

The Tower is an axis whose sustaining function depends upon the emptiness of its summit. Its darkness is the visible form of a withdrawal, and whatever occupies the center destroys the order the center sustains.

Four textual facts support the thesis. The Tower's interior contains no deity, oracle or throne, only rooms displaying the relics of the climber's life and, at the top, a door bearing his name (DT). The would-be occupant of the center, the Crimson King, is locked outside it on a balcony (DT). The cosmos speaks not from the summit but along the Beam—in the humming of the Rose, in the song a writer in Maine hears and obeys (WL; SoS). And nothing is asked of the Tower except that it stand; it sustains the worlds not by acting upon them but by remaining. The genealogy of the figure runs from Laozi's hub and Zhuangzi's pivot through Boethius's *punctum medium*, Dante's *punto*, Luria's *tzimtzum* and Paul's *kenosis* to Lefort's empty place of power (§2.6). The consequence is that the Tower is not a goal but a limit, not a prize but a condition, and that to seek to possess it is to misunderstand it. The adjective in the cycle's title changes sense accordingly. *Dark* names not evil but reticence: the darkness of the withdrawal that lets worlds be. The thesis resolves the crux of the empty rooms.

9.2 *Thesis II — Buttressed Transcendence*

The vertical is an effect of the horizontal. The Tower stands because the Beams hold it, and the quest's cosmological achievements are lateral acts of convocation, accomplished before and independently of the summit.

Panofsky (1951) read the Gothic cathedral as the architectural expression of scholastic articulation, and its decisive engineering device is the flying buttress. The outward thrust of the vaults is carried across open air by external arches to piers outside the building, so that the walls, relieved of their load, can open into glass. The height and light of the nave are purchased by lateral structure outside it. The Beams are the Tower's flying buttresses: its height is the effect of their span.

The plot confirms the architecture. By the time Roland reaches the field of roses, the ka-tet has already defeated the Wolves and ended the harvest of children (WC); liberated the Breakers at the Devar-Toi, after which the Beams begin to heal (DT); secured the Rose through the Tet Corporation (SoS; DT); saved the writer at Lovell (DT); and seen the Crimson King unmade by an artist's eraser (DT). The world is saved horizontally. Nothing in the cosmos depends upon Roland reaching the top: the climb is ethically supererogatory, even gratuitous, and the summit is personal. This is the cycle's most counterintuitive and most important structural fact. The quest succeeds before its hero arrives. The keystone arch and Nāgārjuna's dependent origination (§2.8) state the same

truth in stone and in metaphysics: primacy is relational. The thesis resolves the crux of the ending's apparent futility, for the object of the quest was achieved on the rim.

9.3 *Thesis III — Centripetal Usurpation*

Evil in the cycle is the attempt to seize, fill or complete the center, and Roland's climb is formally identical with the Crimson King's project.

The instances are consistent. The Crimson King wills to destroy the Tower and reign over the Discordia that would follow; Walter's ambition in the final volume is to ascend the Tower and make himself master of all that is (DT); the Old Ones sought to own the Beams as infrastructure; Sombra and Mills seek to enclose the Rose; the Breakers labor, however unwittingly, as the anti-*katechon*. The cycle's literary ancestry supplies the types. Babel builds to make itself a name. The Gnostic demiurge Yaldabaoth mistakes his position for the center and proclaims that there is no other god beside him (*Apocryphon of John*). Dante's Lucifer is fixed at the point "al qual si traggon d'ogne parte i pesi" (*Inf.* XXXIV.111), toward which weights are drawn from every side: the usurper at the center of gravity, made immovable by his own weight—the antipode of the weightless point of *Paradiso* XXVIII. Le Guin's Cob, Herbert's Leto II and Frodo at Sammath Naur complete the series.

Roland belongs to it. He wants the Tower—to reach it, to enter it, to see what is at the top—and his climb past every companion reproduces the Crimson King's solitude. Mordred is the proof. A single child has two fathers, Roland and the Crimson King: the hero and the usurper share a seed, and the child is what their projects have in common—an appetite that devours, a spider at the center of a web, whose first act at birth is to eat Mia, the mother who bore him, and who later eats Walter. Roland can kill him only after Oy, the last member of his host, has died to protect him from this child of his own centripetal will (DT). The closure-hungry reader, who wants to see the top, participates in the same desire, and the Coda's warning is addressed to him. The thesis resolves the crux of Mordred's double paternity.

9.4 *Thesis IV — The Horos Principle*

Arrival at an unoccupiable center necessarily entails return. The loop is the Tower's mercy: a Limit that restores the seeker to himself and prevents his dissolution into the center he sought.

The Valentinian system Irenaeus reports provides the figure (*Adversus Haereses* I.2.2–4). Sophia, the youngest of the aeons, conceives a passion to comprehend the Father, the unknowable Depth, directly. Straining toward him, she would have been swallowed by his sweetness and dissolved into the universal

substance, had she not encountered the power that holds all things firm outside the ineffable greatness. That power is *Horos*, the Limit, which restrains her, restores her to herself and persuades her that the Father is incomprehensible. Irenaeus records the Limit's other names: *Stauros*, the Cross; *Lytrotes*, the Redeemer; *Karpistes*, the Emancipator; *Horothetes*, the Boundary-setter; and *Metagogeus*, the one who leads back.

Roland at the summit is Sophia at the edge of the Depth. To enter the center would be to be annihilated by it or, what is the same thing, to become its usurper. The door that bears his name is *Horos*: the Limit that sends him back and, in sending him back, restores him to himself. It is *Metagogeus*, the one who leads back. And *Horos* is also *Stauros*, the Cross: the Tower stands at the crossing of the Beams, a rose upon the rood (§2.5). The loop is not a sentence but a restraint, and restraint—the *katechon*—is the cycle's cardinal virtue. The *mesure* that Oliver found wanting in the first Roland (§1.3) is what the Tower teaches the second.

The topology of the Limit is ancient. "ὁδὸς ἄνω κάτω μία καὶ ὠυτή," the way up and the way down are one and the same (Heraclitus B60), and beginning and end are common on the circumference of a circle (B103). Passing Lucifer's center, Virgil turns head to feet and the pilgrims' descent becomes an ascent (*Inf.* XXXIV); in Dante's three-sphere the innermost point and the outermost envelope are antipodes (Peterson 1979). Nietzsche's gateway, named Moment, is the place where two eternal lanes meet. Mary Stuart embroidered the principle as a motto: *En ma fin est mon commencement*. The thesis resolves the crux of the summit's refusal: the Tower neither rewards nor punishes; it limits, and the limit returns.

9.5 *Thesis V — Olifantine Repetition*

The loop is repetition with a difference, and the difference is the Horn of Eld, a hollow instrument whose function is to summon a host. The hope of the next circuit is not that Roland will climb better but that he will call.

Three philosophers of repetition define the terms. Kierkegaard's Constantin Constantius holds that repetition and recollection are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been, and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward (Kierkegaard 1843, paraphrased). Deleuze reads Nietzsche's return as selective: what returns is not the same but difference, return as the being of becoming (Deleuze 1962; 1968). Borges's third doctrine of time, of cycles similar but not identical, describes the Tower's loop exactly (§7.3). At the summit Roland reviews his life in rooms, which is recollection; he is returned carrying the Horn, which is repetition recollected forward.

The Horn carries three meanings. It is, first, a hollow: a vessel of air whose use, like Laozi's vessel, lies in its emptiness. It sounds because it is empty, and

so it is a portable kenotic axis, the Tower's emptiness miniaturized and made horizontal. It is, second, the olifant: the horn of the *Chanson* blown too late by a hero too proud to call (§1.3), whose recovery by King's Roland signals that calling is possible again. It is, third, the slug-horn. Browning's word comes from Chatterton's pseudo-medieval Rowley poems, where "slughorne" is used as though it named a trumpet; it is a misprision of *slogan*, which descends from the Scottish Gaelic *sluagh-ghairm*—*sluagh*, a host, and *gairm*, a cry—the war-cry that summons a clan. Browning's Childe blew a host-cry at the Tower's threshold before phantom peers ranged on the hills. Etymologically the Horn is the host-cry, and the difference between the circuits is the capacity to convoke.

The formal consequence is that the Horn reconciles the Coda's two endings. Susannah's ending is the host without the hub; Roland's is the hub without the host; the Horn, carried into the next circuit, is the possibility of the hub encircled by a host—a Tower approached by a convoked fellowship that will not climb it in order to possess it. Browning's Childe blew among the dead, at arrival. The next Roland may blow among the living, before arrival, and in blowing call for help: the one act his pride refused at Jericho Hill and the first Roland's pride refused at Roncevaux. The thesis resolves the crux of the Horn's return.

9.6 *Corollary — The Transfer of the Horn*

Roland does not remember his previous circuits; the memory that makes the loop a repetition with difference lives in the reader, who thereby becomes the Horn's bearer and the host's last member.

Roland retains, of his prior circuits, only a faint ache of recognition. The memory lives elsewhere. Barthes argued that rereading, a practice a culture of consumption discourages, alone saves the text from repetition, since those who never reread are condemned to read the same story everywhere (Barthes 1970, paraphrased). The rereader of *The Dark Tower* holds what the protagonist lacks: knowledge of the price, memory of the dead, the meaning of the Horn. Chiang's Louise is the model (§8.10). Knowing the ending, she chooses the journey, and the choice is not fatalism but love. King's habitual name for his audience, the Constant Reader, names precisely the one who remains constant while the hero forgets.

Reading, on this account, is convocation. The reader joins the ka-tet as its last member, sharing *khef* across the frame, and each rereading is a further turn of the wheel in which the reader carries forward what Roland cannot. The cycle's final agent is neither the author, who has withdrawn, nor the hero, who forgets, but the reader, who remembers. The corollary resolves the crux of the doubled ending: the reader is the one who holds both endings at once.

9.7 *Objections and replies*

First objection: the loop is simply punishment. Punishment requires a judge, and the Tower has no occupant (Thesis I); the return with the Horn signals grace rather than sentence. Even read penally, the structure is purgatorial, not infernal. Dante's Purgatory is a mountain climbed in circuits, its terraces disciplining the same dispositions by repeated exercises that change the soul. Purgation is repetition with a difference.

Second objection: the ending is authorial exhaustion or commercial convenience. The argument concerns the text's structure, not the author's motives; and the 2003 revision of TG, undertaken alongside the final volumes, retrofits the beginning to the end with deliberate care (§1.9). An evasion does not rewrite its own origin.

Third objection: the resonances are imposed. The graded method (§0.4) confines claims of influence to attested sources and admits Grade C resonances only where they resolve cruxes the attested sources leave open. Each thesis above names the crux it resolves: the empty rooms, the ending's apparent futility, Mordred's paternity, the summit's refusal, the Horn's return and the doubled ending.

Fourth objection: the Tet Corporation's capitalism contradicts the anti-enclosure reading. The objection is conceded in part. The cycle cannot imagine protecting a commons except by purchasing it, a limit of its political imagination and a mark of its late Vichian age. Yet the purchase functions katechontically, restraining the market by the market's own instrument, and the Rose's final setting, in a garden open to passers-by (DT), points beyond property toward access.

Fifth objection: race. The objection is conceded without remainder. The cycle makes Black suffering a ground of the host's formation (§5.3). Odetta is maimed by a white man's two attacks, taken into Mid-World by Roland against her will, sexually assaulted by a speaking ring's demon while helping to bring Jake through, and then occupied by Mia to bear the child of the hero and the usurper. Susannah's departure, which emancipates her from Roland's story, does not repay that debt. The present thesis sharpens rather than dissolves the problem. If the host is the cycle's ethical center, then the terms on which its members are drawn into it are the cycle's ethical test, and on this test the cycle is found partly wanting.

Sixth objection: if ka is a wheel, where is freedom? Ka structures the rim; the hub is empty. On the Boethian model (§2.6), fate governs the circumference and providence rests at the center, and nearness to the center is freedom from fate. Freedom in the cycle is therefore not the power to seize the center but the capacity to stand in relation to an emptiness that no one controls—which, on the rim, is the freedom to choose whom to call.

9.8 *Commala: the dance at the rim*

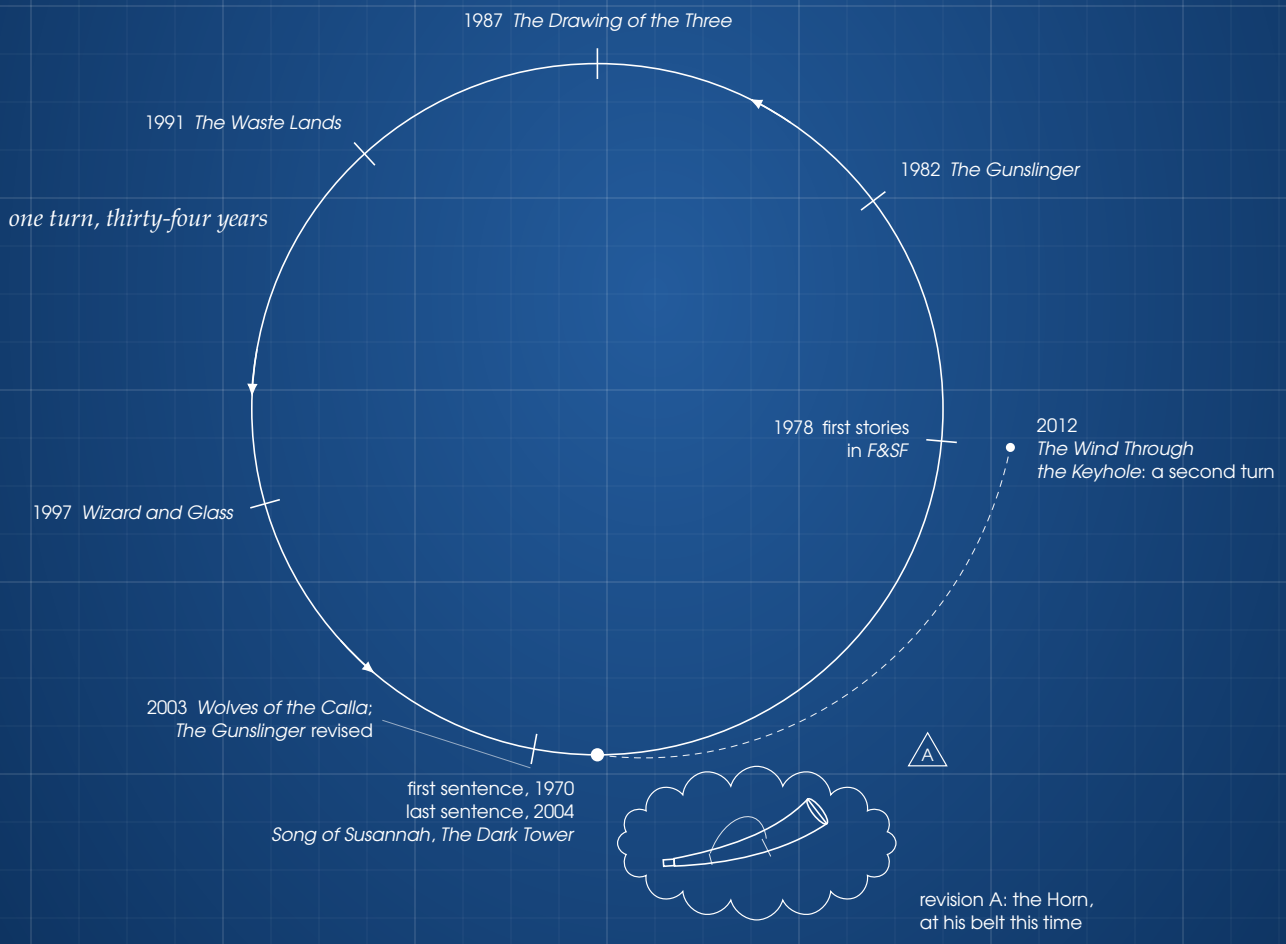
In the Calla, at the feast where the town must decide whether to trust the gunslingers, Roland dances the Commala, the rice dance, faster and longer than anyone present has seen it danced, and wins the town (WC). It is the only time the gunslinger dances, and the scene is the cycle's ethical emblem. The Commala celebrates the rice, the host's harvest and the commons' life, and it is danced in a ring around an empty floor. Its antecedents are exact. David "danced before the LORD with all his might" (2 Sam. 6:14) before the ark, above whose cherubim the invisible God was said to be enthroned upon an empty seat. Zarathustra confesses that he could believe only in a god who knew how to dance, and teaches that one must have chaos within oneself to give birth to a dancing star (*Zarathustra*, Prologue 5; I, "On Reading and Writing," paraphrased). The ethic of convocation is a choreography: to dance at the rim rather than climb to the hub.

The theses and the corollary compose a single figure. *The Dark Tower* is a **katechontic romance**: a quest-romance whose success consists in the restraint of its own completion; whose center must be kept empty by those who love it; whose hero is saved by being returned; whose Horn is a host-cry; and whose final agent is the reader who remembers.

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Conclusion

The Man in Black Fled Again



Reread in the light of the five theses, the cycle's first sentence is no longer a sentence about pursuit. It is a sentence about a follower who has not yet learned to call.

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"The man in black fled across the desert, and the gunslinger followed." On a first reading the sentence is linear, the syntax of the chase that the Western and the quest-romance share: a quarry, a pursuer, a direction. On a rereading it is circular, and its verb becomes its crux. The gunslinger *follows*. He is defined by what he pursues—his shadow, in Jung's terms; the cause of his desire, in Lacan's; his fate, in Freud's—and the sentence places him, grammatically and ethically, in second position. Its setting changes meaning too. The desert is the kenotic space par excellence: the wilderness in which a generation walked for forty years so that a people might be formed, a journey Deuteronomy remembers as a humbling ("thou shalt remember all the way which the LORD thy God led thee these forty years in the wilderness, to humble thee," Deut. 8:2); the desert of the anchorites, in which the self was to be emptied; the vacated space of *tzimtzum*; the room the Tower's withdrawal leaves for worlds. It is also the landscape in which a horn carries farthest, because nothing is in the way.

The words of the first and last sentences are identical; their meanings are not. Borges demonstrated the principle in "Pierre Menard, Author of the Quixote" (1939), whose protagonist composes chapters word-for-word identical with Cervantes's and yet, the narrator insists, far richer, because written from within a different history. The closing sentence of *The Dark Tower* is a Menard effect. The reader who reaches it knows what the gunslinger does not: that the Horn of Eld now hangs at his belt, that the summit is empty and must stay so, that the host was the achievement and the climb the confession. The sentence has not changed. The reader has. That is the whole of the Transfer of the Horn, performed in fourteen words.

The dissertation claims six contributions. It offers, first, a unified structural account of the cycle's ending, derived from the cycle's own cosmology rather than imposed upon it: the loop follows from what the Tower is. It proposes, second, a generic category, the *katechontic romance*, which can be tested beyond King—on Tolkien's quest of renunciation, on Le Guin's *The Farthest Shore*, on *Groundhog Day*—wherever a quest's success consists in the restraint of its completion. It constructs, third, a typology of fictional centers—the throne, the balance, the machine, the completion, the absent god and the empty hub—applicable across speculative fiction. It models, fourth, a graded comparative method, distinguishing attested, transmitted and resonant connections, suitable for popular texts with high-literary genealogies, where source-hunting and free association have too often been the only alternatives. It reads, fifth, metafiction as kenosis rather than irony, a reading that may illuminate other fictions in which authors enter their works not to dominate but to serve. And it articulates, sixth, an ethics of reading as convocation, in which the reader's memory is the medium of a story's moral development across repetitions.

Several lines of further research follow. The Marvel adaptation of the cycle

(2007–2017), plotted by Robin Furth, retells the story with differences and invites analysis as an Olifantine repetition in a visual medium. The 2017 film directed by Nikolaj Arcel, which its makers presented as a further turn of the wheel marked by the Horn, is a sequel by repetition whose troubled reception tests the claim that the Horn's meaning depends upon a remembering audience. King's later fiction continues the cycle's preoccupations outside it: *The Institute* (2019), in which children with psychic gifts are harvested in a Maine facility, is the Breakers' camp without a Tower; *Fairy Tale* (2022), a portal-quest in which a sundial turns time backward, domesticates the loop. And the communities of Constant Readers who reread, annotate and argue over the cycle constitute a host in practice, whose habits of reading would reward empirical study as the lived form of the corollary.

Browning's poem ends not with an entrance but with a breath: "Dauntless the slug-horn to my lips I set, / And blew." The katechontic romance ends in the same place, with the instrument at the lips and the threshold uncrossed. The Tower stands. Its summit is empty. The desert waits, and this time the Horn is at the gunslinger's belt. Whether he will set it to his lips, and whom it will summon, the cycle leaves to its last member, the reader, who alone remembers that he must. *En ma fin est mon commencement.*

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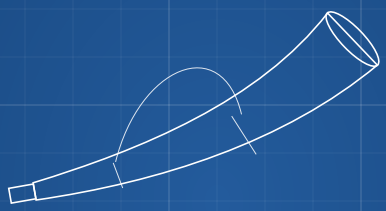
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Keywords

Stephen King
The Dark Tower
quest-romance
katechontic romance
kenotic axiality
Olifantine repetition
buttressed transcendence
centripetal usurpation
Horos principle
convocational ethics
Horn of Eld
Childe Roland
Robert Browning
Chanson de Roland
Arthurian romance
Grail quest
T. S. Eliot
The Waste Land
Weird Western
dying earth
multiverse
axis mundi
empty center
kenosis
tzimtzum
Daoism
Boethius
Dante
Valentinian Gnosticism
katechon
political theology
Carl Schmitt
Claude Lefort
sovereignty
sacrifice
scapegoat
René Girard
Omelas
eternal recurrence
repetition
Kierkegaard
Deleuze
trauma
repetition compulsion
Lacanian drive
Jungian individuation
alchemy
Rosicrucianism
metalepsis
metafiction
strange loop
authorial kenosis
rereading
reader-response theory
inoperative community
double consciousness
comparative literature
speculative fiction
philosophy of literature



And blew.

Robert Browning, 1855